InCad

User Manual

An Autodesk Inventor / Alibre style workbench for FreeCAD
Version 0.5.5 — test build
FreeCAD 1.1 (tested with 1.1.3) · macOS on Apple Silicon

This manual describes InCad as it is in build 0.5.5. Screen names (ribbon tabs, buttons, dialog fields) are written exactly as they appear on screen. What changed from build to build is in CHANGES.txt; installation in short is in README.txt. October 2026.

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1 About InCad

InCad gives FreeCAD the look and the working habits of Autodesk Inventor and Alibre Design.

InCad is a **workbench** for FreeCAD: a module that FreeCAD loads like its own Part Design or Sketcher workbenches. When InCad is active it replaces FreeCAD's toolbars and panels with an Inventor-style interface:

- a **ribbon** with tabs that change with what you are doing (part, sketch, assembly);
- a **Model Browser** with one history for the whole part, sketches under the features that use them and an **End of Part** marker you can drag;
- a **Parameters** panel where every dimension and feature value has a name and can be used in formulas;
- **feature dialogs** with a live preview, **OK**, **Apply +** and **Cancel**;
- **marking menus** on the right mouse button, and Inventor's mouse navigation;
- Inventor-like **sketching**, **assemblies** with constraints, joints and degrees of freedom.

FreeCAD underneath

Everything InCad makes is ordinary FreeCAD geometry: a part is a FreeCAD Part Design body, a sketch is a Sketcher sketch, an assembly uses FreeCAD's own Assembly joints. Your files stay normal **.FCStd** files that FreeCAD opens with or without InCad.

The **FreeCAD** button at the top right of the window (**Return to FreeCAD**) brings FreeCAD's own interface back at any time; choose **InCad** in FreeCAD's workbench selector to come back.

A file that was not made in InCad opens as well. The Model Browser then says **Not an InCad part** and offers **Convert to InCad Part** (for a file with one solid) and **Open in FreeCAD**.

This build: 0.5.5, a test build

0.5.5 is a test build. Assemblies came in 0.2.0, Move Face in 0.3.0, InCad's own sketch Offset and Concentric in 0.4.0, **Text** and **Emboss** in 0.5.0, STEP and STL export in 0.5.1. New in 0.5.2: big parts work much faster (recomputing, editing an early feature, clicking a face), and a slot or two arcs can be dimensioned by their **outer edges** (5.3). 0.5.3 makes Text and sketch patterns, deleting, every new or changed value (only the features that use it are rebuilt), the first change after opening a file and every feature preview faster, and adds ⚙ ▸ **Show Log File**. New in 0.5.4: **Emboss on a sphere** (6.16) and ⚙ ▸ **Display Quality** (3.8); in 0.5.5 Construction switches only the selected lines (5.7) — CHANGES.txt has the full list.

> **Please:** save your work often and work on **copies** of files that matter to you. If something looks wrong, tell us — chapter 11 says what to send.

2 Installation

Install InCad once with FreeCAD's Addon Manager; updating is the same few steps.

Requirements

- A Mac with Apple Silicon (M1, M2, M3, M4 …).
- FreeCAD 1.1 for macOS Apple Silicon (InCad is tested with FreeCAD 1.1.3), from **www.freecad.org/downloads.php**.

Intel Macs, Windows and Linux are not supported in this build.

Install with FreeCAD's Addon Manager (recommended)

1. Unzip the InCad archive. You get a folder with README, CHANGES and this manual, and a folder named **InCad**. Put the unzipped folder somewhere it can stay for now, for example in Downloads.
2. Copy the path of the **InCad** folder — the one *inside* the unzipped folder: select it in Finder and press ⌥ ⌘ C (Copy as Pathname). The path ends in `…/InCad`, not in `.zip` and not in `…-macOS-arm64`.
3. Start FreeCAD and open **FreeCAD ▸ Settings…** (Preferences…). Choose **Addon Manager** in the list on the left.
4. Under **Custom repositories** click **+**. Paste the path from step 2 into **Repository URL**. Leave **Branch** as it is. Click **OK**, then **OK** again to close Settings.
5. Open **Tools ▸ Addon Manager**. Find **InCad** in the list, select it and click **Install**.
6. Restart FreeCAD and choose **InCad** in the workbench selector.

After the install the unzipped folder is no longer needed.

Install by hand (if the Addon Manager way does not work)

1. Quit FreeCAD.
2. In Finder choose **Go ▸ Go to Folder…** (⇧ ⌘ G) and paste `~/Library/Application Support/FreeCAD/v1-1/Mod`. If there is no **Mod** folder, go to `…/FreeCAD/v1-1` and create a folder named **Mod** there.
3. Copy the **InCad** folder from the unzipped archive into that **Mod** folder. The result must be `…/FreeCAD/v1-1/Mod/InCad/InitGui.py` — not `…/Mod/InCad/InCad/InitGui.py`.
4. Start FreeCAD and choose **InCad** in the workbench selector.

The first start

The first time, InCad asks what to make and in which units: **Part** (one part file) or **Assembly** (place and constrain part files), and **Millimeters** (mm, ISO threads listed first) or **Inches** (in, UNC/UNF threads listed first). With **Remember my choice** checked, **New** makes the same kind of file without asking next time. Click **Create**.

To bring the question back, turn on **Tools ▸ Options ▸ Ask on New** on the ribbon, or choose ⚙ ▸ **Units for New Files ▸ Ask every time**.

Start FreeCAD in InCad

To make InCad the workbench FreeCAD starts with:
FreeCAD ▸ Settings… ▸ Workbenches ▸ Available Workbenches ▸ Startup ▸ Default workbench: InCad.
(In FreeCAD 1.1 this setting is under Workbenches, not under General.)

Update to a new build

1. **Tools ▸ Addon Manager ▸** select **InCad ▸ Uninstall**. Quit FreeCAD.
2. Unzip the new build and copy the path of its **InCad** folder (⌥ ⌘ C).
3. **FreeCAD ▸ Settings… ▸ Addon Manager ▸ Custom repositories**: select the old path, remove it with **–**, and add the new path with **+**.
4. **Tools ▸ Addon Manager ▸ InCad ▸ Install**, then restart FreeCAD.

Installed by hand: quit FreeCAD, replace the `Mod/InCad` folder, start FreeCAD.

Uninstall

Tools ▸ Addon Manager ▸ select **InCad ▸ Uninstall**, then restart FreeCAD. Installed by hand: quit FreeCAD and delete the `Mod/InCad` folder. You may also delete the log file `~/Library/Logs/InCad.log`. Your .FCStd files keep working in plain FreeCAD.

3 The InCad window

A short tour: what each area of the window is for.

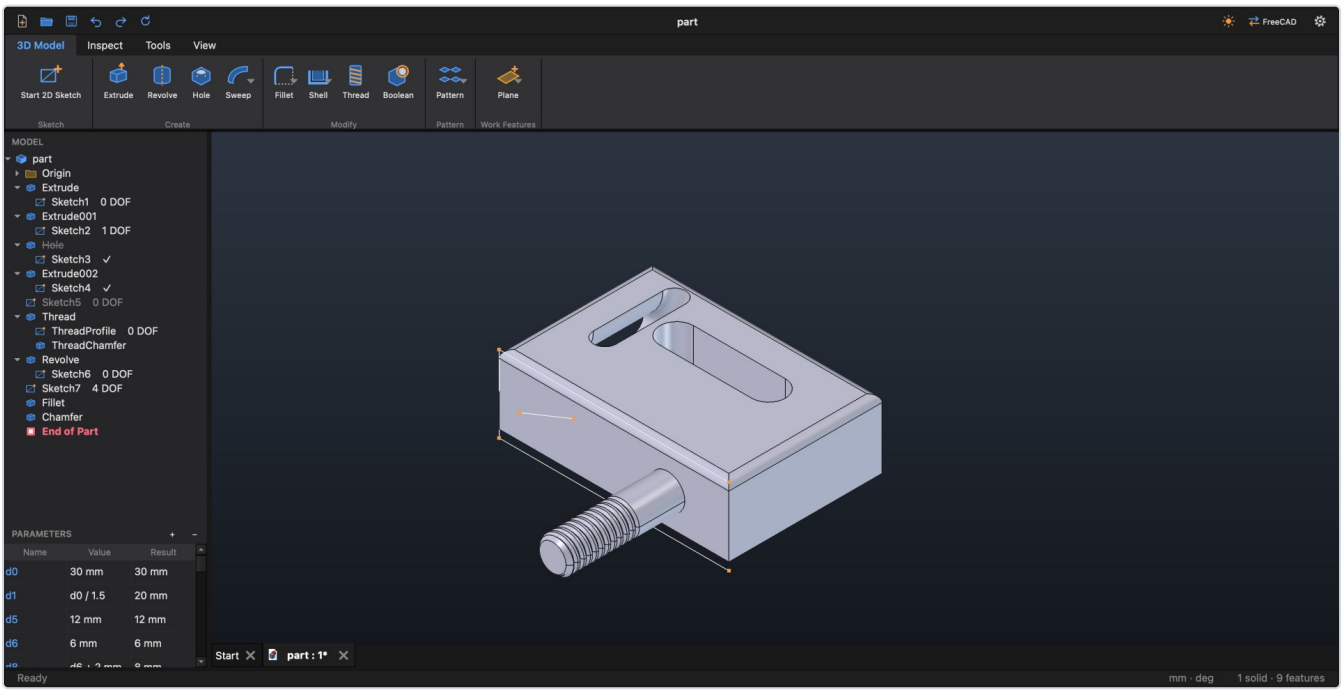


Figure 1. The InCad window: the title strip and ribbon at the top, the Model Browser with the Parameters panel on the left, the model in the middle, the ViewCube and navigation strip on the right, the status line at the bottom.

3.1 Title strip

The strip at the very top holds quick buttons — **New**, **Open**, **Save**, **Undo**, **Redo** and **Update** — the name of the file, and on the right **Light / Dark**, **FreeCAD** (Return to FreeCAD) and ⚙ (InCad settings).

Update recomputes the model and redraws the browser and the view. Use it if the view and the browser ever seem out of step with the model; in an assembly it also brings in parts that changed (see 9.10).

3.2 Menus

InCad keeps a short menu bar: **File** (New, New Assembly, Open, Save, Save As, Close, Quit), **Edit** (Undo, Redo) and **View** (Light / Dark, Zoom All, Home View, Shaded, Wireframe, Assembly Context, Parameters, Return to FreeCAD, Ribbon Size). Everything else is on the ribbon and in the marking menus.

3.3 The ribbon

The ribbon's tabs depend on what is open:

Mode	Tabs
No file, or a file not made in InCad	**Get Started** (New, New Assembly, Open), View
A part	**3D Model**, **Inspect**, **Tools**, **View**
Editing a sketch	**Sketch**, **View**
An assembly	**Assemble**, **View**

A button with a small arrow is a **split button**: it runs the command shown, and its arrow lists the variants (for example Rectangle ▸ Center Rectangle, 3-Point Rectangle …). Hover over a button for its full name and a tip. **View ▸ Ribbon Size** (or ⚙ ▸ **Ribbon Size**) switches between **Small** and **Large**. Appendix B lists every command of every tab.

3.4 The Model Browser

The **MODEL** panel on the left is the history of the part, as in Inventor:

- The top row is the part. Under it: **Origin** (XY, XZ and YZ Plane, X, Y and Z Axis, Center Point), then **Solid Bodies (n)** when the part has more than one solid (chapter 7), then the features in the order they were made — one history for every solid of the part.
- A sketch sits under the feature that uses it. A sketch row shows ✓ when it is fully constrained, or how many degrees of freedom are left (**2 DOF**).
- **End of Part** marks where the model ends. Drag it up to see (and work on) the part as it was at that point; features below it are greyed and not computed. Right-click a feature ▸ **Move End of Part Here** does the same. Drag it back down to the end when you are done.
- Row colours: a feature that failed is **red** (hover over it for the reason); a suppressed feature is greyed and ~~struck through~~; a hidden item is dimmed.

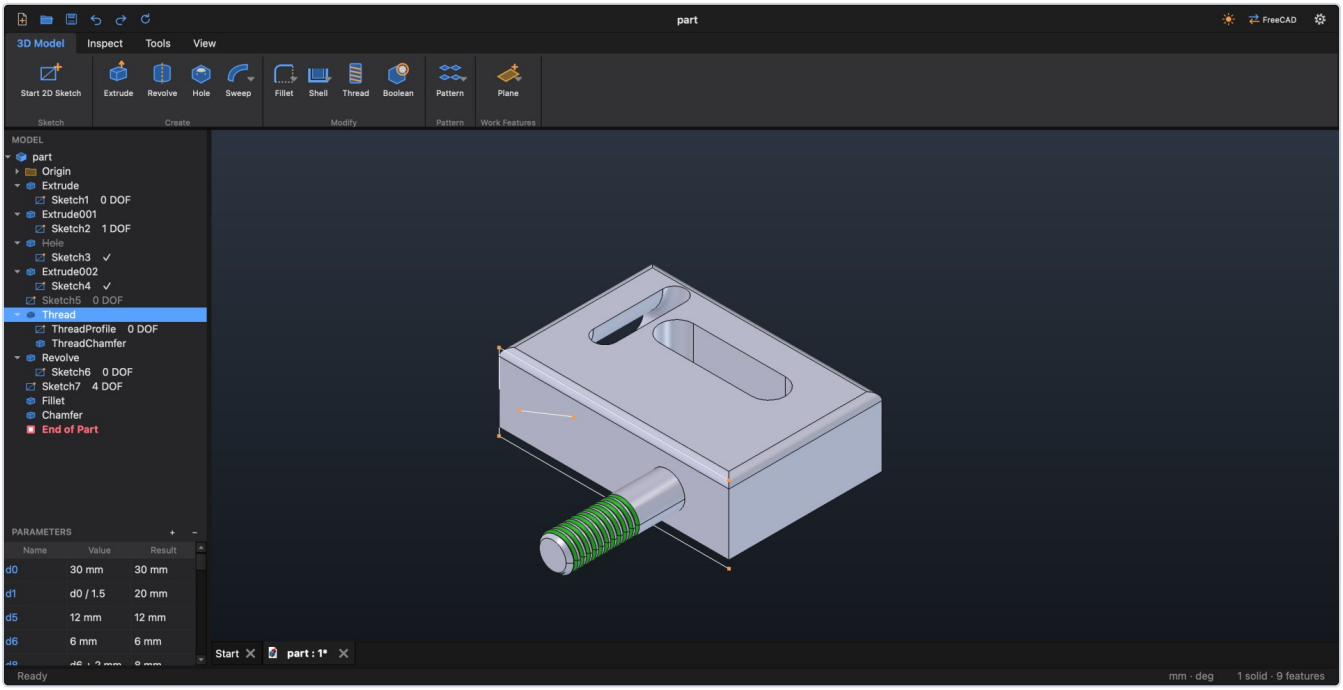


Figure 2. Click a feature in the browser and its faces light up on the model.

Click a row to select it: the faces the feature made light up in the view (figure 2). A hidden plane, axis, point or sketch is shown while its row is selected and hidden again when you select something else. **Double-click** a row to edit it: a feature opens its dialog, a sketch opens for editing, a plane starts a new sketch on it. With ⇧ or ⌘ you can select several rows.

Right-click a row for its marking menu (chapter 4):

Row	Commands
A feature or sketch	Edit, Move End of Part Here, Suppress / Unsuppress, Rename, Show in Window, Start 2D Sketch, Delete, Hide / Show
A solid (Solid Bodies)	Hide / Show, Rename, Show in Window, Delete
An origin plane or axis	Start 2D Sketch, Hide / Show

- **Show in Window** lights up the feature's faces and zooms the view to them. Its opposite, **Show in Browser** (right-click a face in the view), opens the browser at the feature that made that face.
- **Suppress / Unsuppress** turns a feature off without deleting it. A thread is suppressed together with the helper steps InCad made for it; picking a feature's profile sketch means the feature.
- **Delete** removes a feature together with everything InCad made for it (thread profiles, Boolean helpers, assembly cuts), as one undo step. ⌫ or Del deletes the selection. When the delete affects more than the row — a solid used by a Boolean, the main solid, a Split with pieces — InCad asks first and says what will go.
- **Hide / Show** works on solids, assembly parts, origin planes and axes, the Center Point and sketches.

3.5 The Parameters panel

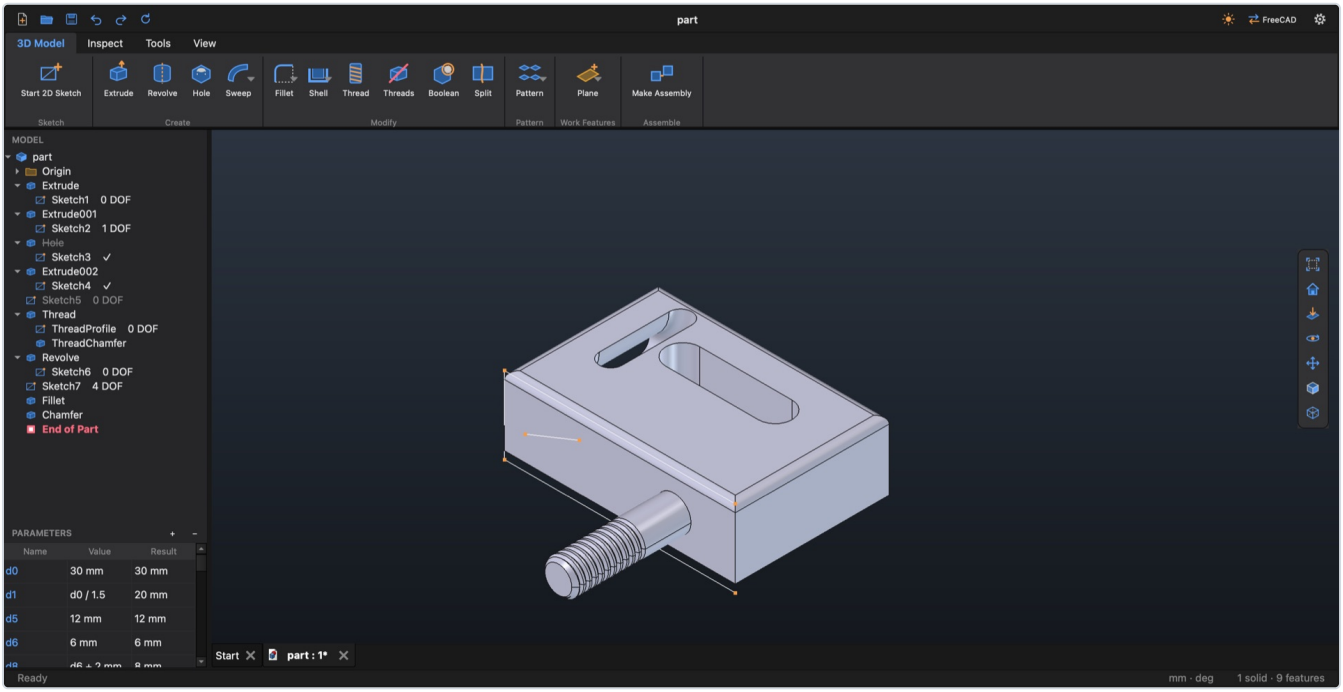


Figure 3. The Parameters panel: every dimension and feature value has a name; the Value column takes numbers with units or formulas, Result shows what they come to.

Below the browser, **PARAMETERS** lists the part's values in three columns: **Name**, **Value** (what you typed — a number or a formula) and **Result**.

- **Model parameters** (shown in the accent colour) are made automatically: every sketch dimension and every feature value gets the next free name **d0, d1, d2 …**; assembly constraint values are named after the constraint (**Mate1**, **Angle1** …). Type a new name over a model parameter to rename it — formulas that use it follow.
- **Your own parameters**: click **+**, type a name, press Tab and type the value (`Width`, `40 mm`). Use the name in any value box or dialog field.
- Change a value in the Value column and the model updates.

- **–** removes the selected parameter. A value that is still used (by a feature or a formula) is not removed: the status line says what uses it. This is how you clean up values left behind by deleted features.
- While a value box or a dialog field is open, click a parameter's name to insert it into the formula.

View ▸ Windows ▸ Parameters (or the marking menu) moves the keyboard focus to the panel.

3.6 Values, units and formulas

Wherever InCad asks for a length or an angle you can type:

- a number, in the file's units (`12`), or with units (`12 mm`, `0.5 in`, `30°`);
- a parameter name (`d3`, `Width`);
- a formula (`d0/2`, `Width − 2*d3`, `d3*2`).

A value that is a formula updates whenever the values it uses change.

3.7 The status line

At the bottom of the window: on the left, what to do next (for example "Pick a plane or a flat face for the new sketch") and messages — in orange or red when something did not work, so look here first when "nothing happens". On the right: the units of the file (**mm · deg**), while sketching the sketch's freedom (**DOF: 3** or **Fully constrained ✓** — click it to see the free geometry), and the size of the part (**2 solids · 14 features**).

3.8 Light, dark and the settings menu

Light / Dark on the title strip (also **View ▸ Appearance** and the marking menu) switches the theme in one click. The ⚙ menu holds InCad's settings:

⚙ menu	Choices
Theme	Match macOS, Light, Dark
Ribbon Size	Small, Large
Units for New Files	Ask every time, Always millimeters, Always inches
Dimension Display	How sketch dimensions are labelled: Value (40), Name (d3), Expression (d3 = 40)
Display Quality	**Normal** (faster) or **Fine** (smoother curves): how finely round faces are drawn. Fine keeps a highlight on a ball or a fillet free of facets; it changes only the drawing, never the part, and does not mark a file as changed. Fine by default on a Mac.
Show Log File	Shows InCad's log (InCad.log) selected in the Finder — the file to send with a problem report (chapter 11)
Mouse Navigation	On: InCad's mouse (LMB+RMB orbit, right-click menu). Off: FreeCAD's own navigation style applies.

3.9 Undo and Redo

⌘ Z undoes, ⇧ ⌘ Z redoes (also the title strip buttons and the NW / NE slots of the marking menu). Every operation is **one** undo step: a feature made in a dialog, a delete with its helpers, a hide, a drag of an assembly part. Inside a feature dialog, Undo steps back through the dialog's own changes. Undo also works in a sketch.

While a feature dialog is open, commands that would interfere with it (Save, Undo outside the dialog, editing a sketch) are refused with "Finish the … dialog first". Click **OK** or **Cancel** first.

3.10 Files

New (⌘ N) makes a part or an assembly (as chosen at the first start), **File ▸ New Assembly** always an assembly. **Open** (⌘ O), **Save** (⌘ S), **Save As** (⇧ ⌘ S) work on the file in front. **Close** (⌘ W) asks whether to save changes (**Save**, **Don't Save**, **Cancel**); **Quit** (⌘ Q) asks about every changed file. Each open file has its own tab above the view.

4 Mouse, views and marking menus

InCad uses Inventor's mouse: the left button selects, both buttons orbit, the right button opens marking menus.

4.1 Mouse

Action	What it does
Left click	Select. ⇧-click or ⌘-click adds to the selection.
Left + right button drag	Orbit around the point under the cursor.
Middle button drag	Pan.
Wheel	Zoom at the cursor.
Right click	Marking menu (in the view and in the Model Browser).
Right button drag	Flick: runs the marking-menu command in that direction without waiting for the menu.
Double click	In the browser: edit the row (a feature, a sketch, an assembly part). In a sketch: edit a dimension, or the pattern of a copy.

No middle button? **Orbit** and **Pan** on the navigation strip (right edge of the view) or on the View tab turn the left button into orbit or pan; click the button again to stop.

⚙ ▸ **Mouse Navigation** switches InCad's mouse handling off; FreeCAD's own navigation style then applies.

> **Sketch tools:** while FreeCAD's line (polyline) or spline tool is drawing, a right click finishes the chain, as in FreeCAD, instead of opening the menu.

4.2 Marking menus

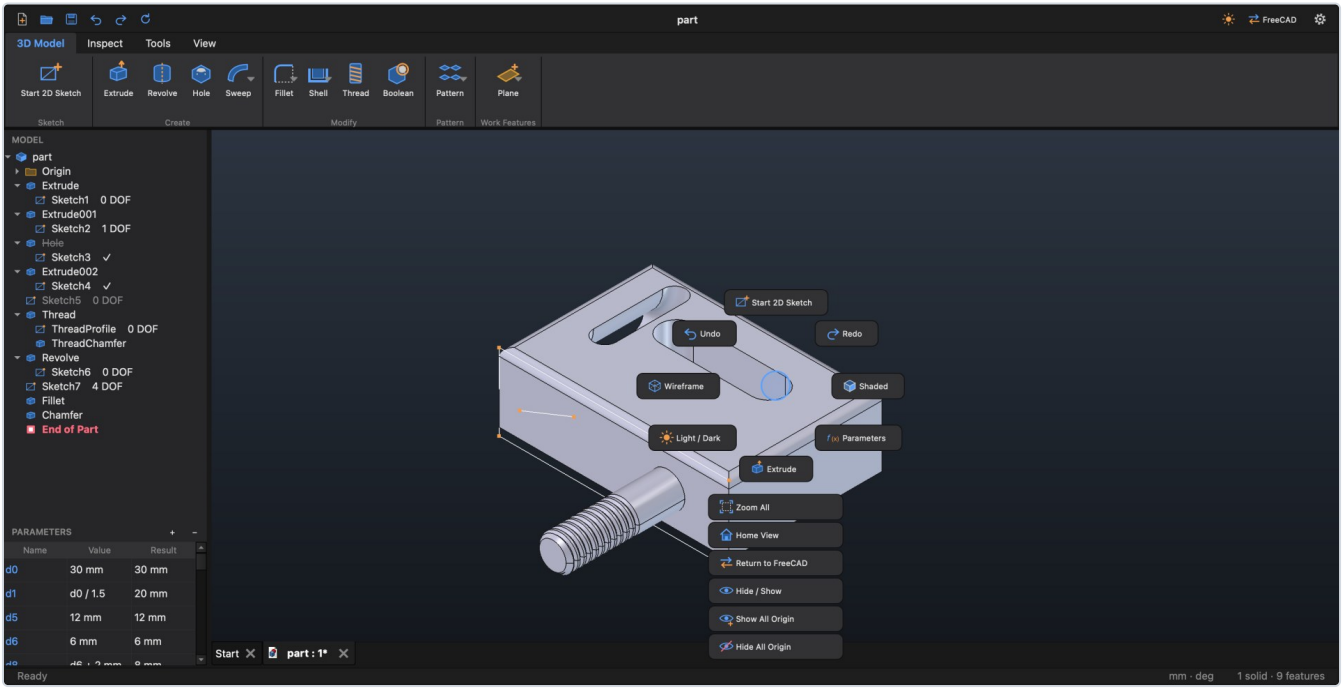


Figure 4. The marking menu: eight commands around the cursor, a short list below.

A right click opens a ring of eight commands around the cursor (north, north-east … north-west) and a short list below it. What it offers depends on what is under the cursor — empty space, a face, an edge, a sketch, an assembly part, a browser row. Once you know where a command sits, **flick**: press the right button, drag towards the command and release — no need to wait for the menu.

Under the cursor	Ring (N, S, E, W first)	List
Empty space (part)	N Start 2D Sketch, S Extrude, E Shaded, W Wireframe, NW Undo, NE Redo, SE Parameters, SW Light / Dark	Zoom All, Home View, Return to FreeCAD, Hide / Show, Show All Origin, Hide All Origin, Make Assembly, Move Face
A face	N Start 2D Sketch, S Extrude, E Shaded, W Wireframe, NW Undo, NE Look At, SE Home View, SW Zoom All	Show in Browser, Zoom Selection, Hole, Fillet, Move Face, Thread, Hide / Show
An edge	N Look At, S Zoom Selection, E Fillet, W Chamfer, NW Undo, NE Redo, SE Home View, SW Zoom All	Show in Browser, Shaded, Wireframe, Hide / Show
In a sketch	N Finish Sketch, S Dimension, E Circle, W Undo, NE Line, SE Rectangle, SW 3-Point Arc, NW Trim	Stop Tool, Delete, Show / Hide Constraints, Constraint List, Look At, Construction, Project Geometry, Edit Pattern, Delete Pattern — and, on a line or point, Delete for each of its constraints (section 5.6)
Empty space (assembly)	N Place, S Mate, E Rigid, W Create, NW Undo, NE Zoom All, SE Home View, SW Ground	Edit, Hide / Show, Suppress, Remove from Assembly, Flush, Insert, Return to FreeCAD
A face of a part (assembly)	N Mate, S Flush, E Angle, W Tangent, NE Look At, SW Ground	Edit, Hide / Show, Suppress, Remove from Assembly, Rigid, Parallel, Perpendicular, Zoom Selection
An edge of a part (assembly)	N Insert, S Rotational, E Cylindrical, W Slider, SW Ground	Edit, Hide / Show, Suppress, Remove from Assembly, Rigid, Parallel, Perpendicular, Angle, Zoom Selection
No file open	N New, S Open, E Light / Dark, W Return to FreeCAD	—

The browser rows have their own menus (chapter 3; assembly rows in chapter 9).

4.3 View commands

On the **View** tab (and partly on the navigation strip and the View menu):

Command	What it does
Light / Dark	Switch the theme.
Zoom All	Fit the whole model in the view.
Home View	The standard isometric view.
Look At	Look straight at the selected face or plane; while sketching with nothing selected, straight at the sketch.
Zoom Selection	Fit the selection in the view.
Orbit, Pan	The left button orbits or pans until you click the button again.

Shaded, Wireframe	Visual style. Wireframe lines are drawn light in the dark theme and dark in the light theme.
Section	Cut the view open (section 8.4). Click again to close.
Section by 3 Points	Click three marked points for the section plane.
Hide / Show	Hide or show the selected solids, assembly parts, origin items or sketches.
Show All / Hide All	Show All Origin, Hide All Origin: every origin plane, axis and the centre point.
Assembly Context	In a part opened from an assembly: show or hide the other parts around it (9.9).
Degrees of Freedom	In an assembly: draw the DOF symbols on every free part (9.7).
Parameters	Move the keyboard focus to the Parameters panel.

5 Sketching

Sketches work as in Inventor: draw roughly, then dimension and constrain. Every dimension has a name you can use in formulas.

5.1 Starting a sketch

1. Select a flat face of the part or a plane (in the view or the browser) — or select nothing.
2. Press S, or click **3D Model ▸ Sketch ▸ Start 2D Sketch**, or right-click ▸ **Start 2D Sketch** (N in the marking menu).
3. With nothing selected, InCad shows the origin planes and a small panel **New sketch on** with **XY · Top**, **XZ · Front** and **YZ · Right**: click a button, or click a plane or a flat face in the view. Esc or **Cancel** gives up.

Double-clicking a plane in the browser also starts a sketch on it. To edit an existing sketch, double-click it in the browser (or right-click ▸ Edit).

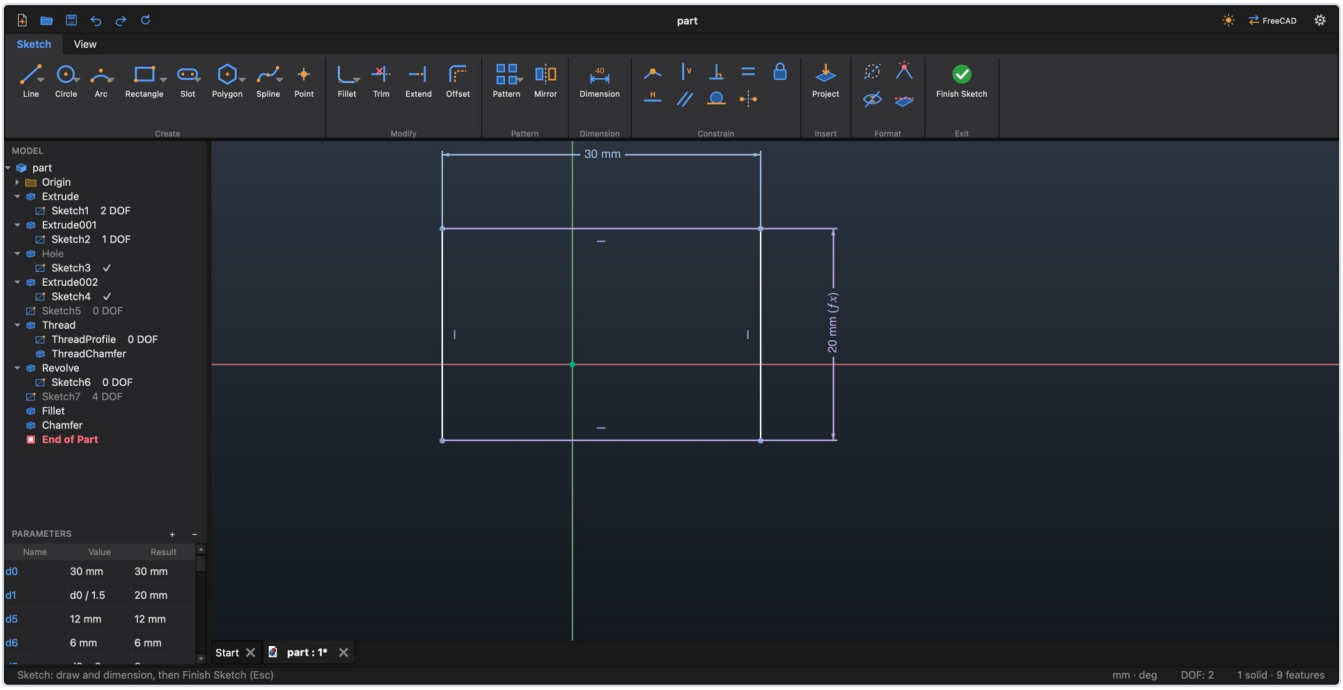


Figure 5. Sketch mode: the ribbon shows the Sketch tab; the status line shows how many degrees of freedom are left.

To leave the sketch: **Sketch ▸ Exit ▸ Finish Sketch**, N in the marking menu, or Esc (the first Esc stops a running tool).

5.2 Drawing tools

All on **Sketch ▸ Create**. The tools are FreeCAD's Sketcher tools; split buttons hold the variants.

Button	Variants	Key
Line	Line (a chain of lines; M while drawing switches between line and arc), Single Line	L
Spline	Spline (through points), Control-Vertex Spline	
Circle	Circle (centre, radius), 3-Point Circle, Ellipse, 3-Point Ellipse	C
Arc	3-Point Arc, Center Arc, Elliptical Arc	A

Rectangle	Rectangle (corner, width, height), Center Rectangle, 3-Point Rectangle, 3-Point Center Rect., Rounded Rectangle	R
Slot	Center-to-Center Slot, Overall Slot (the two outer ends, then the width), Center Point Slot (the centre, one end's centre, then the width), Arc Slot, Flat-End Arc Slot	
Polygon	Hexagon, Triangle, Square, Pentagon, Octagon, Polygon (N sides)	
Point	A sketch point (hole centres, for example)	

Sketch ▸ Modify: **Fillet** and **Chamfer** (sketch corners), **Trim** (X), **Extend**, **Offset**. **Sketch ▸ Pattern** has the sketch patterns (5.9) and **Mirror**.

Offset (InCad's own): click a line — the whole shape it belongs to is taken (a rectangle, a polygon, a chain drawn line by line); ⌘-click adds more shapes. The copy follows the pointer; a click places it. Corners stay sharp, a single line gives one parallel line, a circle or an ellipse gives a ring. One dimension drives the offset and the value box opens on it. Geometry selected before the command is taken at once. **Mirror** and the patterns also take the whole shape from a click on one side.

Typing values while drawing. While a tool draws, type the length, radius or angle directly; Tab moves to the next field. Esc or **Stop Tool** (marking menu) ends the tool.

Delete geometry or dimensions: select them and press ⌫ or Del.

5.3 Dimensions

1. Press D (or **Sketch ▸ Dimension**, S in the marking menu).
2. Click a line, a circle, two points or two lines, and place the dimension.
3. A value box opens: **d3 = 40 mm**. Type the value (or a formula) and press Enter or ✓; Esc or × cancels. A value that cannot be used turns the box red and says why.

Double-click a dimension to change it later. Every dimension gets a name (**d0, d1 ...**) and appears in the Parameters panel, where you can rename it (`Width`) — see 3.5.

Formulas. In the value box, click another dimension in the sketch or a parameter in the Parameters panel to insert its name: `d0/2`, `Width - 2*d3`. A formula may use other dimensions and parameters, but not a reference (driven) dimension of the same sketch.

A slot's length, or the distance between two arcs or circles. It can be measured three ways, and the value box of such a dimension shows three buttons to choose: **Centers** (centre to centre), **Overall** (outer edge to outer edge — a slot's overall length) and **Gap** (inner edge to inner edge — what FreeCAD's Dimension gives when you click two arcs). A click switches the dimension at once; it keeps its name and the box opens on its new value. **Sketch ▸ Dimension ▸ Overall Dimension** makes the overall one directly: click one edge of a slot (or two arcs or circles) and type the value. A new overall value makes the slot longer, not wider. If the slot's length is already fixed by other dimensions, the new dimension is a reference (driven) one that follows. A dimension used in a formula keeps its kind.

⚙ ▸ **Dimension Display** chooses how dimensions are labelled: the value (40), the name (d3) or both (d3 = 40).

5.4 Constraints

Sketch ▸ Constrain: **Coincident**, **Concentric** (two circles, arcs or ellipses: their centres are tied), **Horizontal**, **Vertical**, **Parallel**, **Perpendicular**, **Tangent**, **Equal**, **Symmetric**, **Fix** and **List** (the Constraint List, 5.5). Select the geometry, then click the constraint (or click the constraint, then the geometry).

The status line shows the sketch's degrees of freedom — **DOF: 3**, or **Fully constrained ✓**. Click it, or **Sketch ▸ Format ▸ Show Free Geometry**, to select the geometry that can still move.

Sketch ▸ Format ▸ Show / Hide Constraints hides or shows the constraint symbols (dimensions stay); F8 shows them, F9 hides them.

5.5 The Constraint List

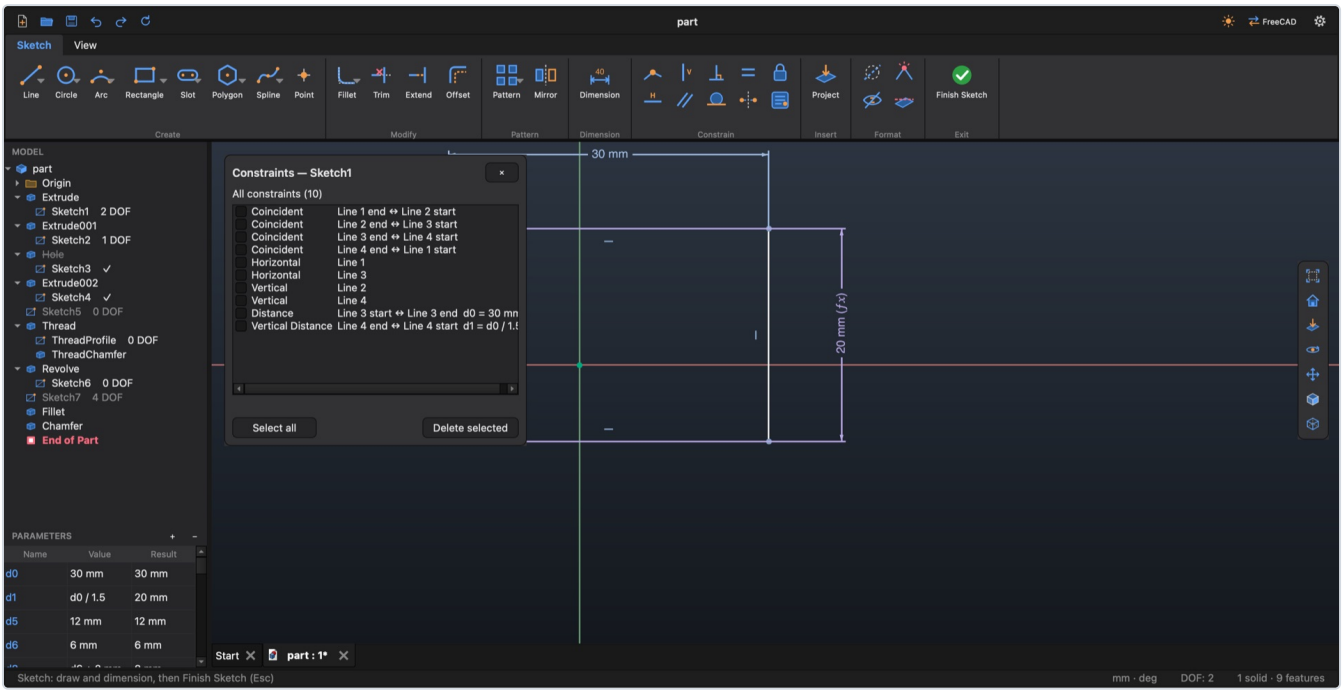


Figure 6. The Constraint List: every constraint of the sketch, filtered by the picked line or point.

Open it with **Sketch ▸ Constrain ▸ List**, or right-click in the sketch ▸ **Constraint List**. It lists every constraint of the sketch with what it ties and its value — including the ones that have no symbol to click, such as coincident points and a point on a line.

- Pick a line or a point in the sketch: the list shows only that element's constraints. Pick nothing to see them all.
- Select a row to see its constraint in the sketch.
- Check rows (or **Select all**) and press **Delete selected**. This is one undo step.
- Constraints that hold a sketch pattern together, and dimensions used in a formula, are kept; the window says why.

5.6 Deleting constraints with the right button

Right-click a line or a point in the sketch: the marking menu's list then has a **Delete …** entry for each of its constraints (for example **Delete Horizontal**, or **Delete Distance (Line 2) d4 = 20 mm**), **Delete all constraints (n)**, and **Constraints…**, which opens the Constraint List for that element.

5.7 Project Geometry and construction

Sketch ▸ Insert ▸ Project Geometry brings edges and points of the part into the sketch. As in Inventor, projected edges are **normal lines**, ready to be part of a profile. They follow the part when it changes.

Sketch ▸ Format ▸ Construction works two ways:

- with geometry selected (also projected edges), it switches that geometry — only the selected edges

— between normal and construction (for projected edges the status bar says which they are now: they look much the same either way);
- with nothing selected it is a mode: everything you draw is construction until you click it again.

Construction geometry does not take part in profiles; use it for axes and helper lines. It is drawn **orange** and dashed, thinner than the normal lines — a projected edge switched to construction too.

5.8 Seeing the sketch

- **Slice Graphics** (F7, **Sketch ▸ Format**) cuts away the part in front of the sketch plane, so you can see a sketch inside the part.
- **Look At** (marking menu) turns the view straight onto the sketch.
- In the dark theme the part is drawn darker while a sketch is open, so the sketch's lines stand out (the part's own colour does not change).
- After **Finish Sketch**, a sketch that no feature uses and that is an **open contour** (a path for a Sweep, say) stays visible in the model; a closed sketch, and any sketch a feature uses, is hidden. **Hide / Show** overrides this for any sketch.

5.9 Sketch patterns

Sketch ▸ Pattern repeats sketch geometry. The copies are real sketch geometry, tied to the original: change the original and the copies follow.

Edit Pattern: double-click a copy, or select a copy and right-click ▸ **Edit Pattern**. **Delete Pattern** (right-click on a copy) removes the copies; the original stays. If you delete single copies, the pattern is rebuilt the next time you edit it.

Rectangular

Field	Meaning
Geometry	The lines, arcs, circles and points to repeat.
Distribution	**By spacing** (a direction, a count and a spacing) or **Equal spacing** (a count spread evenly between two limits).
Direction 1, Flip direction	A line of the sketch, or the X or Y axis.
Count, Spacing	How many (2), how far apart (10 mm).
From, To	Equal spacing: the limits — a line or a point.
Two directions	By spacing: a second direction with Direction 2, Count 2 and Spacing 2.

Circular

Field	Meaning
Geometry	What to repeat.
Axis	The centre point (any point of the sketch, a projected point or the origin).
Count, Angle	How many (4) over which angle (360°).
Distribution	**Fitted** (the copies fill the angle) or **Between copies** (the angle is the step from one copy to the next).
Flip	The other way round.

Along Path

Field	Meaning
Geometry	What to repeat.
Path	The path's lines, arcs and splines, in order.
Count	How many (3).
Distribution	**By spacing** (with Spacing, measured along the path) or **Fit to path**.
Orientation	**Identical** (every copy as the original) or **Follow path** (turned with the path).
Flip	Go along the path the other way.

5.10 Text

Sketch ▸ Create ▸ Text writes words in the sketch; Extrude raises them (Join) or engraves them (Cut), Emboss wraps them round a cylinder or a cone, or projects them onto a sphere (6.16).

1. Press **Text** — the cursor shows an orange **Aa** — and click two corners: a construction box (orange, dashed, never extruded) is drawn and the dialog opens on it.
2. Type the words (several lines are fine), pick the font and the size, and press **OK**.

Field	Choices and meaning
Text	The words; Return starts a new line. Cyrillic works.
Font, Bold, Italic	The Mac's installed fonts; Bold / Italic use the font's own Bold and Italic files.
Mirror	Flips the text left-right, to read it from the plane's other side (a sketch on the underside of a part, or on a plane turned the other way).
Size	The height of the capital letters (5 mm), a named value like any other (3.6).
Placement	**In a box** or **Along a curve**.
Box	The box the text sits in: the one drawn by the two clicks, or a line of any rectangle of the sketch. Dimension or constrain the box (centred on a face, 3 mm from an edge) and the text follows; a tilted box tilts the text.
Horizontal, Vertical	Left / Centre / Right and Top / Middle / Bottom in the box, by the letters themselves. A text longer than the box runs past it.
Fit to the box	The letters scaled so the widest line fills the box's width (never taller than the box); Size then hides.
Curve, Position, Shift, Distance, Flip side	Along a curve: any line, arc, circle, ellipse or spline of the sketch (construction too). Select it before pressing Text and the text runs along it — each letter turned with it, Centre at a closed curve's top, Shift moves it along, Distance lifts it off, Flip side puts it on the other side (inside a ring it then reads at the bottom, as on a coin).
Letter spacing	Extra space between letters (0 mm).

The text is one object (a **Text** row in the browser): double-click it to change the words or the font — its sketch opens with the dialog. While the sketch is open the text follows its box or curve at once, and its outline is drawn on top. A Text that an Extrude or Emboss uses is hidden and shows under that feature.

6 Part features

Every feature opens a dialog with a live preview. This chapter first explains how the dialogs work, then each feature with what to pick and what each option means.

6.1 How feature dialogs work

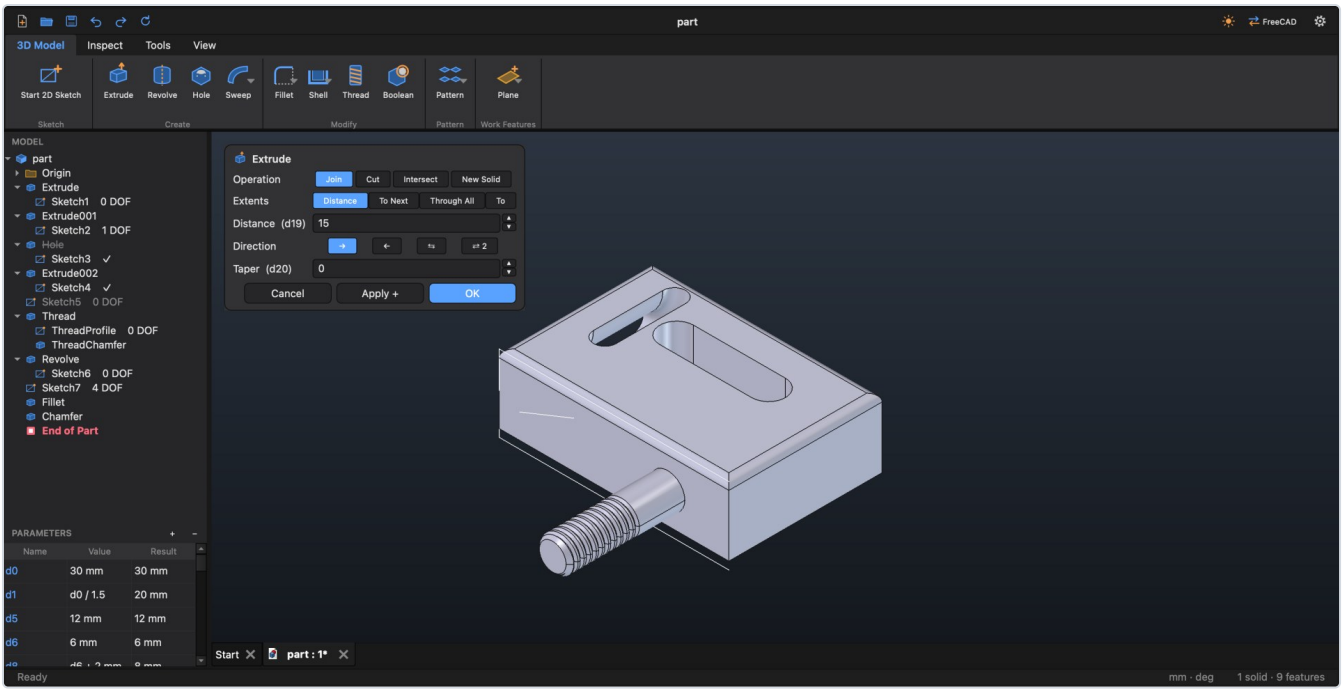


Figure 7. An Extrude being edited: the dialog on the left, the preview on the model. The label "Distance (d19)" says the value is the model parameter d19.

- **Select first or pick later.** Select the faces, edges or sketch first and then click the command — or click the command and pick in the view or the browser while the dialog is open. The highlighted field takes the picks. Click another pick field (**Select…**) to make it take the next picks. While you pick, the shape as it was before the feature is shown, so you can reach every face.
- **The profile.** Extrude and Revolve take the only finished sketch no feature uses yet automatically; if there are several, select one. If a sketch has crossing lines, InCad shows its areas: click the one to use.
- **Preview.** Every change shows on the model at once. While you pick edges or faces, Fillet, Chamfer and Move Face draw the result's new edges over the part in orange. The full check of the result's geometry runs on **OK**; if it finds a problem, the dialog stays open and says what.
- **Values.** Type numbers with or without units, names or formulas (3.6). The ▲ ▼ arrows next to a value — and the ↑ ↓ keys — change it by one unit (1 mm, 1°, 1/16 in); with ⇧ by ten. A formula cannot be stepped. The parameter's name is shown after the field's label, for example **Distance (d19)**; click a parameter in the Parameters panel to insert its name.
- **Choices.** Options are buttons; long lists wrap four to a row. A choice that cannot be used with the current picks is greyed out. Choosing an option that needs a pick starts that pick.
- **Buttons. OK** makes the feature and closes the dialog. **Apply +** makes it and keeps the dialog open for one more of the same kind. **Cancel** or Esc leaves everything as it was.
- **Errors** appear in red at the bottom of the dialog, in plain words ("Pick the cylindrical face to thread"). Sometimes the dialog offers a button with a way around the problem.
- **Editing.** Double-click a feature in the browser (or right-click ▸ **Edit**) to open its dialog again with its

values. As in Inventor, while the dialog of an earlier feature is open the part is shown as of that feature, and only that feature is recomputed as you change values; the features after it are recomputed once, on **OK**. If one of them fails then, the status line says which.

6.2 Extrude E

3D Model ▸ Create ▸ Extrude. Pulls a closed sketch profile into a solid, or cuts with it.

Field	Choices and meaning
Operation	**Join** (add material), **Cut** (remove), **Intersect** (keep only what the extrusion and the part share), **New Solid** (a separate solid, chapter 7). Cut is chosen for you when the sketch lies on or inside the material, Join otherwise.
Extents	**Distance**; **To Next** (up to the next face of the part — if nothing is in the chosen direction, it goes toward the part); **Through All**; **To** (up to a **Face** you pick, flat or curved, or a work plane).
Distance	The length (10 mm).
Direction	→ the default side, ← the other side, ⇆ symmetric (half each way), ⇄ **2** two sides with their own lengths (**Distance 2**, 5 mm).
Taper	Draft angle of the sides (0°).

A Join that does not touch the part becomes a solid of its own; the status line says so. Join and Cut can be switched later in the dialog, unless other features are built on this Extrude.

6.3 Revolve R

3D Model ▸ Create ▸ Revolve. Turns a sketch profile around an axis.

Field	Choices and meaning
Operation	**Join** or **Cut**.
Axis	**Sketch vertical** or **Sketch horizontal** — the sketch's own axes. **Construction / projected line** — a construction line of the sketch or a projected straight edge, chosen in the **Line** list. If the sketch has exactly one such line, it is chosen for you. To revolve around an edge of the part, project that edge into the sketch (an edge perpendicular to the sketch projects to a point and is not offered). **Line, axis or edge** — **Pick** a sketch line, an origin or work axis, or a straight edge in the view. **Two points** — click two **Points** on the part: corners, edge middles, circle centres. They are projected onto the profile's plane, so the axis always lies in that plane.
Extents	**Full** (360°), **Angle** (with **Flip** for the other way), **Two angles** (**Angle** and **Angle 2**, one each way). Angles start at 90°.

For a projected line or two points, InCad keeps a hidden **Revolve axis** under the feature; it is deleted with the feature.

6.4 Hole H

3D Model ▸ Create ▸ Hole. Drilled, counterbored, countersunk and threaded holes.

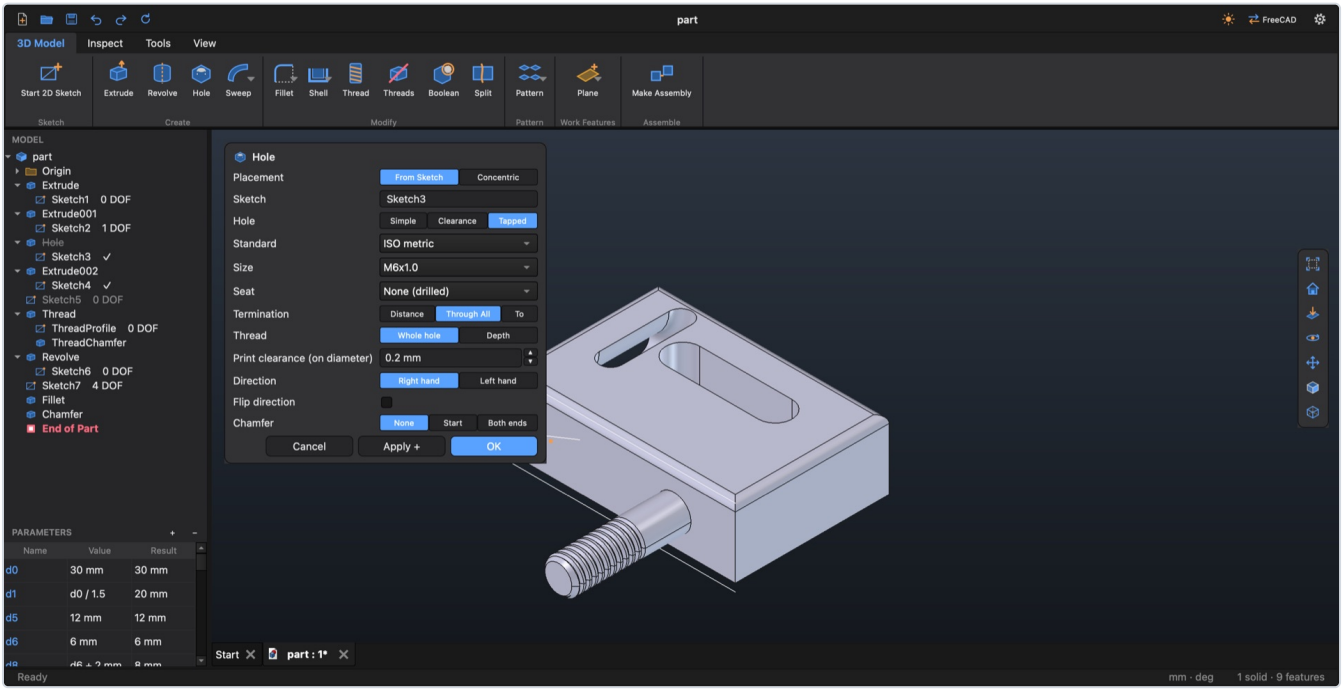


Figure 8. The Hole dialog.

Field	Choices and meaning
Placement	**From Sketch**: a hole at every point and circle centre of the picked **Sketch**. **Concentric**: pick the flat **Face** and a round edge (**Circular edge**); the hole is centred on that edge.
Hole	**Simple** (a **Diameter**, 5 mm), **Clearance** (for a screw: Standard, Size and **Fit** — Close, Normal, Loose), **Tapped** (a modeled thread).
Standard	Clearance and Tapped: ISO metric, ISO metric fine, UNC, UNF, UNEF, NPT, G / BSP, BSW, BSF.
Size	The thread size, or **Auto (from Diameter)**.
Seat	**None (drilled)**, **Counterbore** (C'bore Ø 10 mm, C'bore depth 3 mm), **Countersink** (C'sink Ø 10 mm, C'sink angle 90°), **Spotface** (Spotface Ø 10 mm, Spotface depth 0.5 mm).
Termination	**Distance** (a **Depth**, 10 mm), **Through All** (the default), **To** (up to **To face**, a face or work plane).
Drill point	For Distance and To: **Flat** or **Angle** (**Point angle** 118°).
Thread	Tapped: **Whole hole** or **Depth** (**Thread depth**, 8 mm).
Print clearance (on diameter)	Tapped: how much larger the thread is made so that a printed part fits (0.2 mm, measured on the diameter).
Direction	Tapped: **Right hand** or **Left hand**.
Flip direction	Drill the other way.
Chamfer	**None**, **Start**, **Both ends**, with a **Chamfer size** (0.5 mm): a 45° lead-in at the mouth and, for a through hole, at the exit. A tapped hole is chamfered from the thread's diameter, so a screw starts easily. With a seat only the exit can be chamfered (Start is greyed out).

> **Other threads in a hole:** for Trapezoidal, ACME, print-friendly or custom threads, drill a Simple hole first, then use **Thread** (6.10) on its face.

6.5 Fillet F and Chamfer

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Fillet / Chamfer (a split button). Select the edges, then the command — or pick the edges in the dialog. Also on the marking menu of an edge (E Fillet, W Chamfer).

Feature	Fields
Fillet	**Edges**, **Radius** (1 mm).
Chamfer	**Edges**; **Type**: **Distance**, **Two distances** (Distance, Distance 2) or **Distance + angle** (Distance, Angle 45°); **Flip** swaps the sides for the last two types. Distances start at 1 mm.

The edges must be on the current shape of the part. A click on an edge takes its whole smooth chain (a slot's lines and arcs, a ring in pieces); a click on a **face** takes all its edges, and a second click on it takes them off. While you pick, the part shows as it is and the result is drawn over it as orange outlines.

6.6 Shell

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Shell hollows the part.

Field	Meaning
Remove faces	The faces to open (pick them).
Thickness	The wall (1 mm).
Direction	**Inside** (the outer size stays) or **Outside** (the wall grows outward).

FreeCAD cannot shell a part that already has a modeled thread. The dialog then offers to make the Shell **before** the thread; you can also drag End of Part above the thread, make the Shell there and move End of Part back.

6.7 Draft

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Draft (with Shell) tilts faces for moulding: pick the **Faces**, the **Neutral plane** (the faces keep their size there), the **Angle** (1°); **Reverse** tilts the other way.

6.8 Move Face

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Move Face. Direct editing: pushes or pulls flat faces of the part, the way Inventor does, without going back to the sketch. Select the faces first, then the command (also on the marking menu of a face and of the part) — or pick them in the dialog. Everything is a step at the end of the part's history, a row **Move Face** in the browser: double-click it to change the values, Suppress or Delete it like any feature. One **OK** is one undo step; **Finish move** on top of the right-click menu of the view does the same as OK.

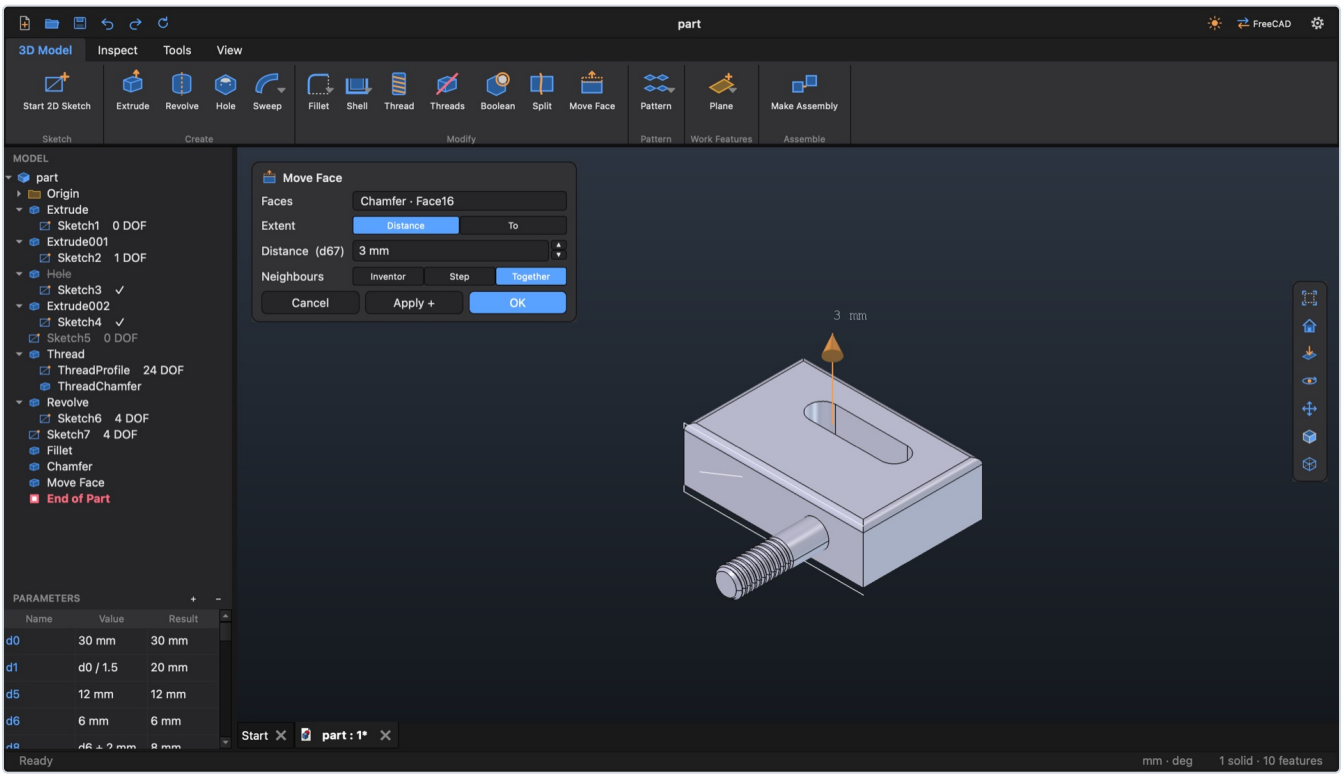


Figure 9. Move Face on the sample part's top, 3 mm, Neighbours Together (its top edges are filleted, so Inventor refuses): the preview, the arrow and the value at its tip.

Field	Choices and meaning
Faces	One or more flat faces. Several faces must face the same way (a boss top and the floor of a pocket, for example); they all move together. Faces looking in different directions are refused: *The faces must be flat and face the same way*. A **round wall** (a cylinder, an extruded ellipse or spline) moves outward or inward by a Distance (To is greyed out for it); one click takes the whole wall.
Extent	**Distance** (a number) or **To** (up to a face or plane).
Distance	The move along the face's outward direction: positive grows the part, negative cuts into it, 0 changes nothing. Units, parameters and formulas work as everywhere (3.6). It starts at 0 mm: type a value or drag the arrow.
To	Pick a flat face or a work / origin plane parallel to the faces, an edge that runs parallel to them (all of it at one height: a level line, an arc or a circle), or a point (a corner or a work point); the faces move to its height. The target may be on another Solid. The distance is the gap, found again on every change, so the faces follow the target if it moves. A tilted target is refused: *Pick a face, plane, edge or point parallel to the faces*.
Neighbours	What the faces next to the moved face do: **Inventor** (as it opens), **Step** or **Together** — see below.

The arrow. While the dialog is open an arrow stands on the first face, along its direction (drawn like the assembly gizmo's arrow). Drag it with the mouse: the face moves, the preview follows, the **Distance** field changes in steps of 0.1 mm and a label at the arrow tip shows the value ("12.5 mm", "-3 mm"). The arrow lights up and the cursor becomes a hand when you are on it. Type a distance and the arrow and the label follow. Dragging replaces a formula or parameter in **Distance** with the dragged value in mm. With Extent **To** the arrow only shows where the face goes; it cannot be dragged.

The three ways the neighbours behave. Take a block with a chamfer on one top edge and pull the top face up:

Neighbours	What happens	When it refuses

Inventor	The neighbours keep their angle and grow or shrink: the chamfer gets taller and the top face narrower. A hole through the face stays a hole, a boss wall slides along.	A neighbour that is round across the move (a fillet, a cone): *A neighbouring face is round: Inventor mode can't follow it yet — try Step or Together*.
Step	Only the face moves, as a straight slab. A slanted or round neighbour stays as it was and a straight wall appears at its edge.	Never because of a round or slanted neighbour; only "too large" (below).
Together	The face and the chamfers or fillets next to it move as one piece, keeping their size; the walls around them grow.	The walls around the chamfer or fillet are not along the move (slanted or round themselves): *The walls around the chamfer / fillet must run along the move — try Inventor or Step*.

Other messages: *The move is too large: a neighbouring face would vanish* (for example a face pushed in further than the chamfer next to it is wide; nothing changes), and *A face to move is no longer there* (an earlier feature removed the face; the Move Face row turns red); a face picked on another Solid is refused: *The faces must be on this Solid*. InCad finds the faces again by their geometry, not by their names: in their plane or — if an earlier change moved them — in the nearest parallel plane where they overlap, so Move Face keeps working when an earlier feature is edited, for example when the block is made taller. The To target is kept by its name, like other features' references.

6.9 Sweep, Loft and Coil

On the **3D Model ▸ Create** split button after Hole. Each has an **Operation**: Join or Cut.

Feature	Fields
Sweep	**Profile** (a closed sketch) along **Path** (another sketch: lines, arcs, splines). **Wall** (Join only) makes a tube: **Thickness** (1 mm) and **Ends** — Both open, Start closed or End closed.
Loft	**Sections**: two or more sketches, in order. The list shows them numbered; ▲ ▼ move a section earlier or later, × removes it. **Ruled** makes straight faces between sections; **Closed** joins the last section back to the first.
Coil	A spring: **Profile** (a sketch), **Axis** (an axis, a sketch line or a straight edge), **Pitch** (5 mm), **Height** (20 mm), **Direction** Right hand or Left hand.

The path of a Sweep is usually an open sketch; open sketches stay visible after Finish Sketch, so you can pick them.

6.10 Thread

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Thread. A real, helical thread — geometry you can print. Select the outside of a shaft or the inside of a hole (a full round face), then click Thread. Also on the marking menu of a face.

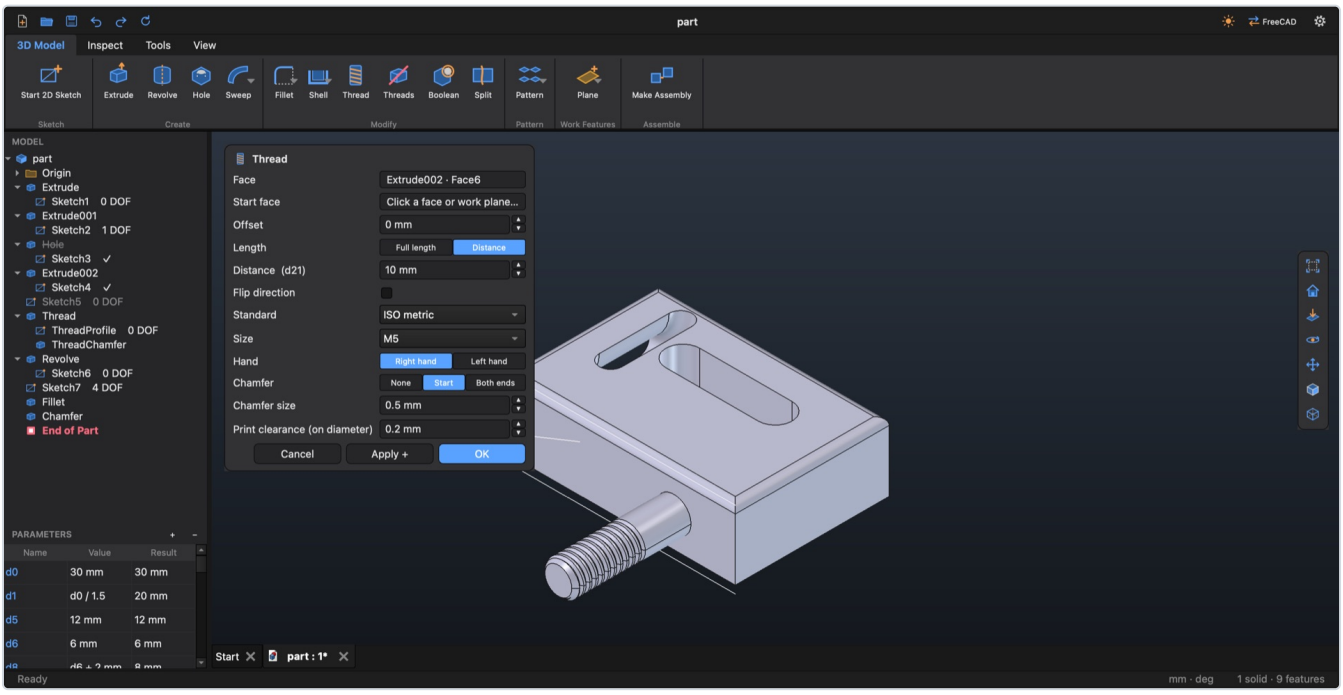


Figure 10. The Thread dialog.

Field	Choices and meaning
Face	The round face to thread.
Start face	Optional: a flat face at the end where the thread starts. Without it the thread starts at the free end (the tip of a shaft, the mouth of a hole); on a through hole or a loose rod, at the chamfered or rounded end.
Offset	Distance from the start (0 mm).
Length	**Full length** or **Distance** (10 mm).
Flip direction	Start from the other end.
Standard	ISO metric, ISO metric fine, UNC, UNF, G / BSP, NPT (tapered), Trapezoidal, ACME, Print-friendly (flat crests, sizes from M3 up) or Custom (**Pitch** 1.5 mm, **Flank angle** 60°, **Depth** 0.9 mm).
Size	A size of the standard, or **Auto (from the face)**: the size that matches the face (a Ø3 hole gets M3, a Ø4 hole M4; a tap-drill hole gets its thread: Ø5.2 → M6, Ø8.5 → M10).
Hand	**Right hand** or **Left hand**.
Chamfer	**None**, **Start** or **Both ends**, with **Chamfer size** (1 mm).
Print clearance (on diameter)	How much room the thread leaves so printed parts fit (0.2 mm on the diameter; 0.3 mm for Print-friendly, set when you choose it). 0 gives the nominal thread.

Sizes that do not match the hole. Any sensible size works in a hole: in a Ø3 hole, M3 fills the hole back to the M3 tap size first, M4 bores it out to the M4 tap size first. These helper steps sit right before the thread in the history; the fill goes only where the hole has a wall all round. A size far off the hole is refused with a message.

On a rod the rod is first turned down to the thread's crests (a **ThreadTrim** step under the Thread), so no thin fin is left on the crests.

Suppress, Delete and Edit on a thread act on the thread together with its helper steps.

6.11 Threads Off / On

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Threads. Modeled threads make redraws slow. Click **Threads** to suppress every thread while you work, and again to bring them back. A thread you suppressed yourself stays off. It also turns off the modeled thread of tapped holes (the holes stay). A suppressed tapped hole keeps its modeled thread off until it is unsuppressed, so it costs no time while it is off.

6.12 Boolean

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Boolean (Inventor's Combine) joins, cuts or intersects solids of the part. Select the base solid, then the tool solid(s), then click Boolean — or pick them in the dialog: click anywhere on a solid to pick it. As in Inventor, the first click is the base (the solid that stays), the next ones are the tools.

Field	Choices and meaning
Base	The solid that is changed.
Tools	One or more other solids. A click on the base while picking tools is ignored.
Operation	**Join**, **Cut** (the default) or **Intersect**.
Clearance (per side)	Cut only: a gap left on each side (0.2 mm), for printed parts that must fit.
Clearance on	Cut only: **Cavity** (the hole is made larger), **Tool** (the hole is exact; a shrunk copy "<Tool> fit" is made for printing), **Split** (half on each).
Keep tool	Off (as it opens): the tool is used up and shows under the Boolean in the browser. On: the tool stays a separate, visible solid — print the pin and the box.

The tools stay editable: change a tool and the result follows. Threads and other complex shapes may refuse a clearance; the dialog then says so.

6.13 Split

3D Model ▸ Modify ▸ Split. The lines of a sketch (lines, arcs, splines) become thin cutting surfaces through the whole part.

Field	Choices and meaning
Sketch	The sketch whose lines cut the part (select it before the command, or pick it).
Mode	**Keep all**: every piece stays; this solid keeps the largest piece and every other piece becomes a solid of its own — hide it, work on it, make it a part (Make Assembly). The pieces keep following the sketch. **Keep picked**: only the pieces you click (**Keep**) stay.

Deleting a Split joins its pieces again; InCad asks first and names the solids that go.

6.14 Patterns and Mirror

3D Model ▸ Pattern: **Rectangular**, **Circular** and **Mirror** (one split button). They repeat features: pick them in the browser or click one of their faces. Picking a fillet, a chamfer or a thread stands for the feature it modifies.

Feature	Fields
Rectangular	**Features**; **Include dependent features** (also repeat what is built on them — the hole in a boss); **Distribution**: **By spacing** (**Direction 1** — a straight edge or an axis —, **Count** 2, **Spacing** 10 mm) or **Equal spacing** (Count copies spread between **From** and **To**: a flat face, an edge or a work plane); **Flip direction**; **Two directions** (Direction 2, Count 2, Spacing 2).

Circular	**Features**, **Include dependent features**, **Axis**: **Axis or edge** (an origin or work axis, a sketch line, a straight or circular edge, a round face — the origin's X, Y and Z show while you pick) or **Two points** (click two points on the part: a hidden work axis through them, drawn as an orange dashed line while the dialog is open), **Count** (4), **Angle** (360°).
Mirror	**Features**, **Include dependent features**, **Mirror plane** (a flat face or a plane).

6.15 Work features

3D Model ▸ Work Features: **Plane**, **Axis**, **Point** (one split button). Choose the **Method**, then pick what it asks for. Work features follow the geometry they were made from.

Work feature	Methods
Work Plane	Offset from plane (Offset 10 mm), Parallel through point, Midplane (between two planes), Angle around edge (Angle 90°), Three points, Normal to edge at point, Tangent to surface at point.
Work Axis	On edge, Two points, Intersection of two planes, Normal to plane through point, Axis of a cylinder, Parallel to edge through point.
Work Point	At vertex, Center of circle, Midpoint of edge, Edge meets plane, Two edges meet.

A "plane" pick takes a flat face or a work or origin plane. Double-click a work plane to start a sketch on it.

6.16 Emboss

3D Model ▸ Create ▸ Emboss (Inventor's Emboss / Engrave) raises a Text or a sketch from a face or cuts it in — any closed profile: letters, a star, a logo. On a **cylinder or a cone** it is wrapped round the face — the letters keep their size and run round it, their height along the radius; on a **flat face** it goes straight; on a **sphere** it is projected along the sketch's normal onto the side the sketch faces, its height along the radius.

1. Put the Text (or sketch) on a plane parallel to the round face's axis: the origin plane through the axis, or a plane touching the face. It lands on the side of the face that looks at that plane.
2. For a sphere: put the sketch on any plane, best one through the sphere's centre or in front of it; the profile lands on the half of the sphere that faces the sketch.
3. Press **Emboss**: the Text (or the selected sketch) is taken as the profile and the **Face** field waits — click the round, spherical or flat face. A sketch left in another solid moves to the solid of the face you click, with the emboss.

Field	Choices and meaning
Operation	**Emboss** (raise) or **Engrave** (cut in). Engrave may cut right through a thin wall, like a stencil: the loose middles of O, A, D fall out.
Depth	The height or depth (1 mm), along the radius on a round face.
Face	A cylinder, a cone, a sphere or a flat face of the part (a flat face must be parallel to the profile).
Around	**As drawn** (the spacing of the Text) or **Evenly round** (the letters keep their widths and spread with equal gaps once round the whole face, the middle one facing the sketch). Greyed out on a sphere.

Emboss is a step in the history like Move Face: it finds its face again when an earlier step changes (a bigger cylinder). Letters past the face's edge are refused: *Some of the profile is off the face*; on a sphere, so is a profile that reaches past the sphere's outline seen from the sketch.

7 Several solids in one part

A part can hold several separate solids — for a tool and the part it cuts, or a part you will print in pieces.

How separate solids are made

- Extrude with **Operation ▸ New Solid**.
- An Extrude ▸ Join that does not touch the part (a box drawn away from it): it becomes its own solid automatically.
- Split ▸ **Keep all**: every piece except the largest becomes a solid.
- Boolean with **Keep tool**, or a "<Tool> fit" copy (Clearance on Tool).

The browser then shows **Solid Bodies (n)** with a row for each solid. The history stays one list: features of other solids name their solid.

Sketching on another solid

A new solid sketched on a face of another solid holds only its own piece; the solid below stays as it is. The sketch follows that face only when it **projects edges** of the other solid; otherwise the face only gave it its plane.

Hide, show, rename, delete

Right-click a solid's row: **Hide / Show**, **Rename**, **Show in Window**, **Delete**. A hidden solid is dimmed in the browser. Delete asks when the solid is used by a Boolean (both go together) or when it is the main solid (the next one becomes the main solid). Selecting a piece in the view and pressing ⌫ deletes that solid.

Make Assembly

When the pieces are ready, **3D Model ▸ Assemble ▸ Make Assembly** turns every separate piece into a part file of its own and links them in a new assembly where they were. See 9.12.

8 Inspect and tools

Measuring, mass, material, section views and options.

8.1 Measure

Inspect ▸ Measure (a split button). Measuring stays live: every change of the selection measures again, and the results show in a small panel. Esc finishes.

Command	Select	Shows
Measure	A face, an edge, a solid, or two items	Area; Length, or Radius and Diameter of a round edge; Volume, Surface and Size of a solid; for two items Distance (and Angle when both have a direction)
Distance	Two faces, edges or points	Distance; between two points also ΔX, ΔY, ΔZ
Angle	Two flat faces or straight edges	Angle
Length	Edges (a loop)	Total length and the number of edges
Area	Faces	Total area and the number of faces

8.2 Mass Properties

Inspect ▸ Measure ▸ Mass Properties shows the part's Volume, Surface area, Mass and Size. The mass uses the density of the part's material (8.3).

8.3 Material

Tools ▸ Material ▸ Material sets the part's material: its density for Mass Properties and its colour. The default is PLA.

Material	Density, g/cm³	Material	Density, g/cm³
PLA	1.24	Nylon	1.14
PETG	1.27	Resin	1.18
ABS	1.04	Aluminium	2.70
ASA	1.07	Steel	7.85
TPU	1.21		

8.4 Section views

View ▸ Visual Style ▸ Section cuts the view open — the model itself is not changed.

- Select a flat face, a plane, or three points first; with nothing selected the section is on the XZ plane.
- A small **Section** panel moves the cut: **Offset** along the plane's normal, **Flip** to look from the other side, **Done** to keep the cut view, **Off** to close it. Clicking Section again also closes it.
- **Section by 3 Points** (the same split button): click three of the marked points — corners, edge middles, circle centres — for the plane.

Section works in parts and assemblies.

8.5 Options

- **Tools ▸ Options ▸ Ask on New**: on, **New** asks Part or Assembly and the units; off, it makes what you chose last time.
- **Tools ▸ Options ▸ Return to FreeCAD**: FreeCAD's own interface (also the **FreeCAD** button on the title strip).
- The other settings are in the ⚙ menu (3.8).

9 Assemblies

An assembly links part files and holds them together with constraints and joints, as in Inventor. The parts stay separate .FCStd files.

9.1 Starting an assembly

- **File ▸ New Assembly**, or **Get Started ▸ New Assembly** with no file open.
- **New** (⌘ N) makes an assembly too if you chose Assembly with **Remember my choice**. **Tools ▸ Options ▸ Ask on New** brings the question back.

An assembly links to part files, so it must be saved before the first part is placed. InCad does this for you: when you place the first part, a new assembly is saved next to that part under its own name; if a file of that name is already there, InCad asks for a name and a folder. **Create** asks you to save the assembly first.

9.2 Placing and creating parts

1. **Assemble ▸ Component ▸ Place** (P) — or N in the marking menu.
2. Choose a saved part (or assembly) file.
3. The first part placed is **grounded** (fixed in place); the next ones are put beside it.

Create asks for a **New part file name** and makes a new, empty part file next to the assembly, placed in it. **Ground** grounds or ungrounds the selected part.

9.3 The assembly browser

In an assembly the browser shows the assembly, one row per part, and **Relationships (n)** with the constraints and joints.

- Each part row shows its **freedom**: **grounded**, **DOF 0** … **DOF 6**, or **DOF ?** when it could not be counted (hover for the reason). A suppressed part shows nothing.
- Under each part row is the part's own history (its sketches and features). A click on one of those rows selects the part; a double-click opens the part file.
- A hidden part is dimmed, a suppressed one struck through.
- Right-click a part (row or in the view) for **Edit**, **Hide / Show**, **Suppress**, **Remove from Assembly**, **Ground** and the constraints (4.2).

9.4 Adding a constraint or a joint

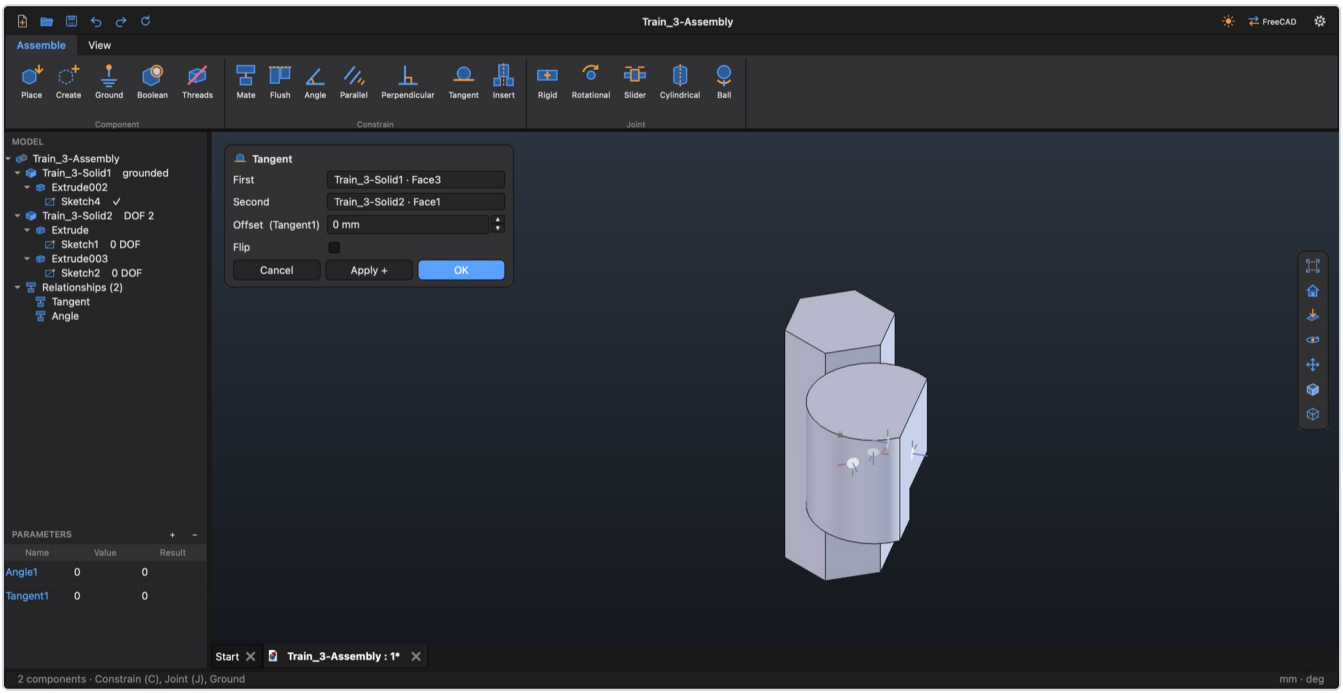


Figure 11. A Mate being made: the dialog with Offset and Flip, the preview in the view.

1. Click the constraint on **Assemble** ▸ **Constrain** or **Assemble** ▸ **Joint** — C is Mate, J is Rigid — or use the marking menu on a face or edge of a part.
2. Pick the **First** item on one part and the **Second** item on another, in the 3D view. The preview moves the part at once.
3. Set the **Offset** or **Angle** if the constraint has one, and **Flip** if the part faces the wrong way.
4. **OK** (or **Apply +** for the next one).

The part that moves is the free one; a grounded part never moves. A constraint that cannot be met together with the others is refused: "Mate conflicts with the other constraints (it can't be met)". Offsets and angles are parameters named after the constraint — **Mate1**, **Flush1**, **Angle1** … — and appear in the Parameters panel.

9.5 Constraints and joints, one by one

Constraint	Pick (First, Second)	What it does	Value, Flip
Mate C	Two faces	Faces against each other, facing each other.	Offset (0 mm). Flip: the faces face the same way instead.
Flush	Two faces	Faces side by side, facing the same direction.	Offset. Flip: which way the faces face.
Angle	Flat faces or straight edges	The two at an angle.	Angle (90°).
Parallel	Flat faces or straight edges	The two stay parallel; the distance stays free.	—
Perpendicular	Flat faces or straight edges	The two stay at 90°.	—
Tangent	A round face and a flat or round face	The faces touch. A round face sits outside the flat face's part by default.	Offset. Flip: outside or inside.
Insert	Two round edges	Axes aligned, the faces of the edges together (a screw in a hole); the part can still turn.	Flip: direction.
Rigid J	A face, edge or point on each part	The two parts are fixed together.	—
Rotational	A face, edge or point on each part	A hinge: turns about one axis only.	Flip: direction.
Slider	A face, edge or point on each part	Slides along one direction only.	Flip: direction.
Cylindrical	A face, edge or point on each part	Turns about and slides along one axis.	Flip: direction.
Ball	A face, edge or point on each part	Turns freely about a point.	—

For joints, a round edge gives its centre and its axis — pick round edges for hinges and shafts.

9.6 The Relationships rows

Every constraint and joint has a row under **Relationships**. **Double-click** a row to edit it. Right-click it for **Edit**, **Delete**, **Suppress / Unsuppress** and **Rename**. A suppressed constraint is struck through; the solver ignores it and its parts stay where they are. Bringing back a constraint that can no longer be met is refused.

9.7 Degrees of freedom

A part's degrees of freedom are the ways it can still move: up to three slides and three turns. InCad counts them against what holds the part (the other free parts are held still while it counts):

- the part row says **grounded**, **DOF n** or **DOF ?** (9.3);
- **View ▸ Visual Style ▸ Degrees of Freedom** (View tab of the assembly) draws Inventor's DOF symbols on every free part — a double arrow for each direction it can slide, an arc for each axis it can turn about (figure 12);
- with that button off, the part under the pointer shows its symbol as a tip.

A fully constrained part (DOF 0) and a grounded part show no symbol.

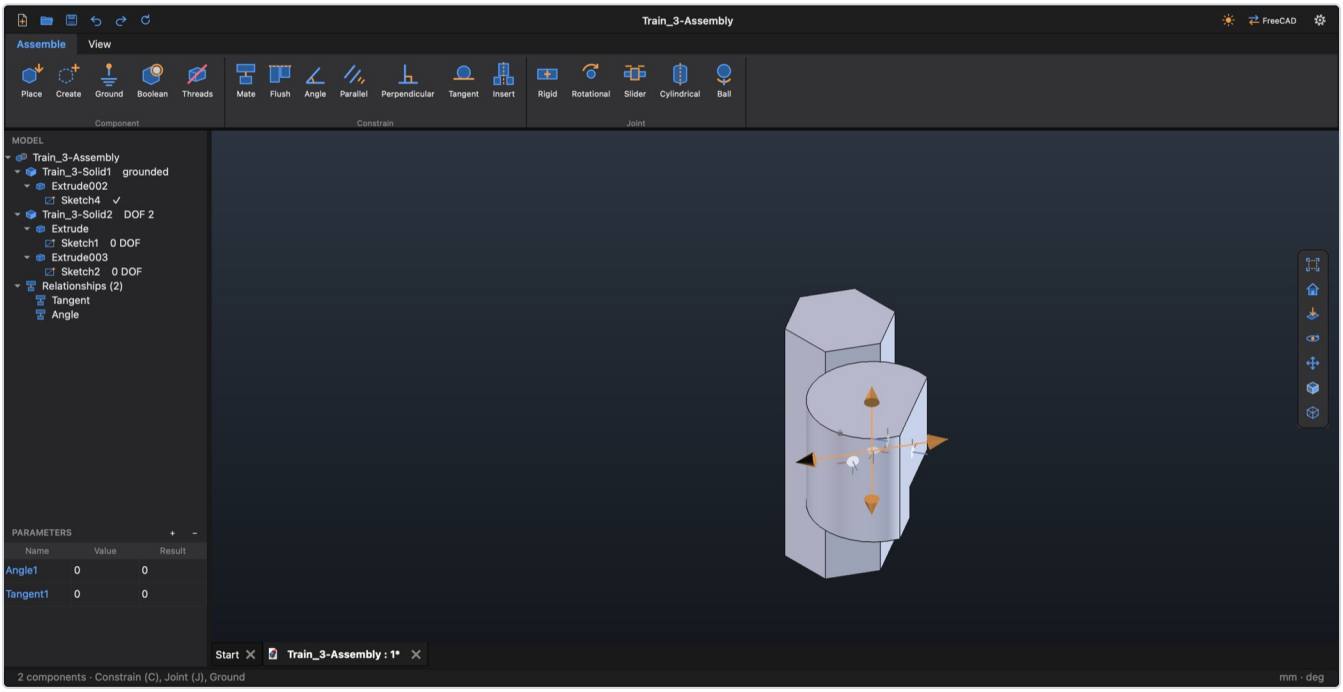


Figure 12. View ▸ Degrees of Freedom on: each part row says grounded or DOF n, and every free part shows its DOF symbol.

9.8 Moving parts

Drag a free part with the left button: it moves only the ways its constraints still let it — a Mated block slides and turns on its face, an inserted pin turns in its hole. The other parts stay where they are, even free ones. A fully constrained part does not move (the status line says "... is fully constrained"); a drag on a grounded part says it is grounded.

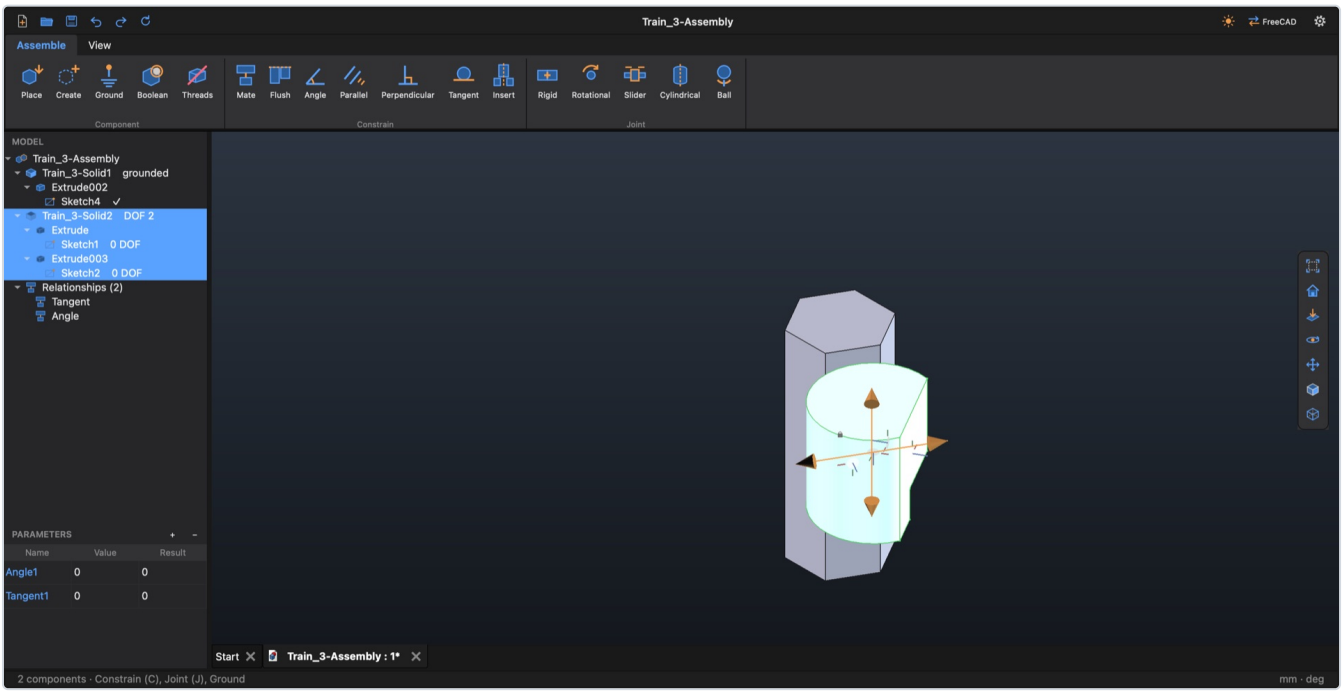


Figure 13. Click a free part for its gizmo: arrows slide the part, arcs turn it.

The gizmo. Click a free part: its DOF symbol becomes a gizmo with an **arrow** for each direction it can slide and an **arc** for each axis it can turn about.

- Grab an arrow to slide the part, an arc to turn it. Handles are easy to catch: the one under the pointer lights up.
- The first arrow is up and down — straight up, or up the slope of a tilted face — where the part can move that way.
- A click on empty space hides the gizmo.

Every drag that moved the part is **one undo step** ("Move part"); ⌘ Z puts the part back. While a constraint dialog is open, dragging is off.

9.9 Editing a part in the assembly

Right-click a part ▸ **Edit** (or double-click its row): the part opens in its own tab, with the other parts of the assembly drawn around it — grey, semi-transparent, at their real places. They are for reference only: they cannot be picked and are not saved in the part. Change the part as usual and save it.

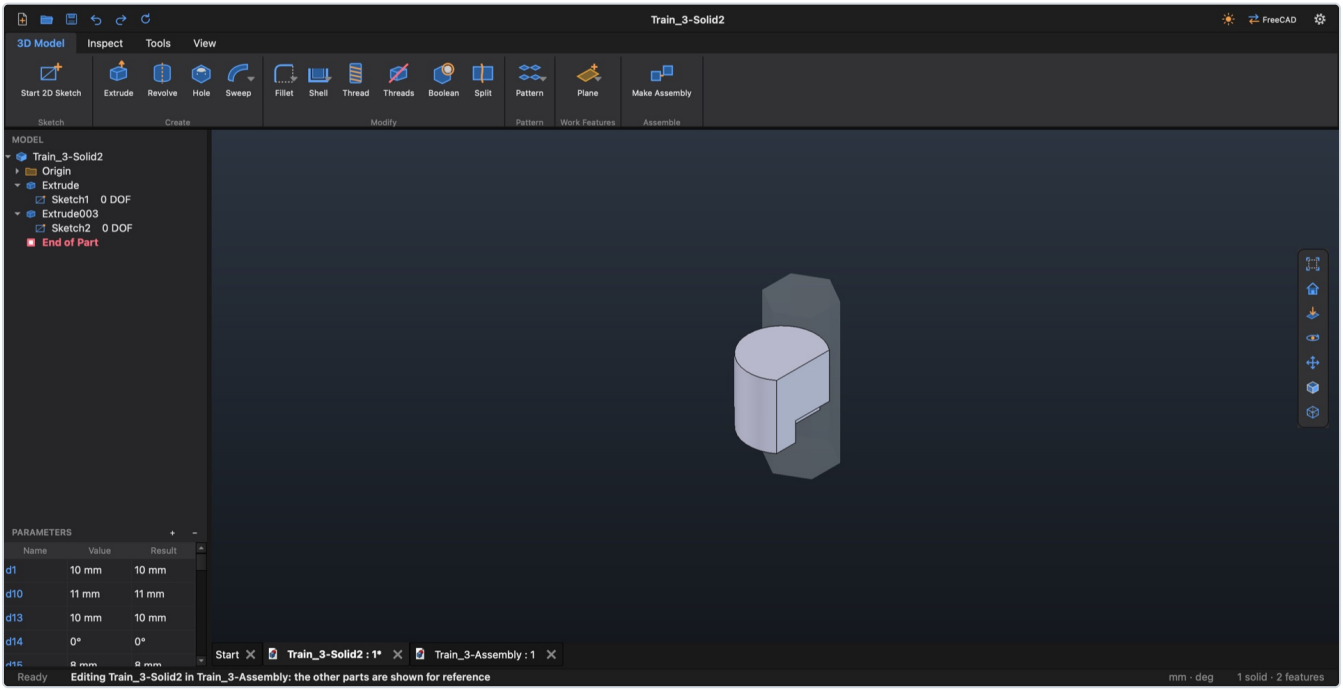


Figure 14. A part opened with Edit from its assembly: the other parts around it, semi-transparent.

View ▸ Assembly Context (View menu, or the View tab of the part) turns the other parts off and on.

9.10 Updating the assembly after a part changed

Back in the assembly's tab after a part changed, InCad asks: **Parts of … changed. Update the assembly now?**

- **Yes** brings the changes in.
- **No** leaves the assembly as it was; the top row of the browser then says ⚡ **Needs update** until you click **Update** on the title strip.

9.11 Hide, Suppress, Remove

Command	What it does
Hide / Show	Hides or shows the selected part; the row is dimmed while hidden.
Suppress	The part is hidden and its constraints are off; again to bring it back.
Remove from Assembly	Takes the part out of the assembly; its part file stays.
Ground	Fixes the part in place, or frees it again.

9.12 Make Assembly from a part

Model a product as one part with several solids (chapter 7), then turn it into an assembly in one step.

1. Save the part — the new files go into its folder.
2. **3D Model ▸ Assemble ▸ Make Assembly**, or right-click in empty space ▸ **Make Assembly**.
3. The dialog lists the new files: the **Assembly** name and one name per piece (**Piece 1 (grounded)**, Piece 2 …) with its volume. Hover over a row to see the piece marked in the view. Change the names if you like.
4. Click **OK**. The new assembly opens.

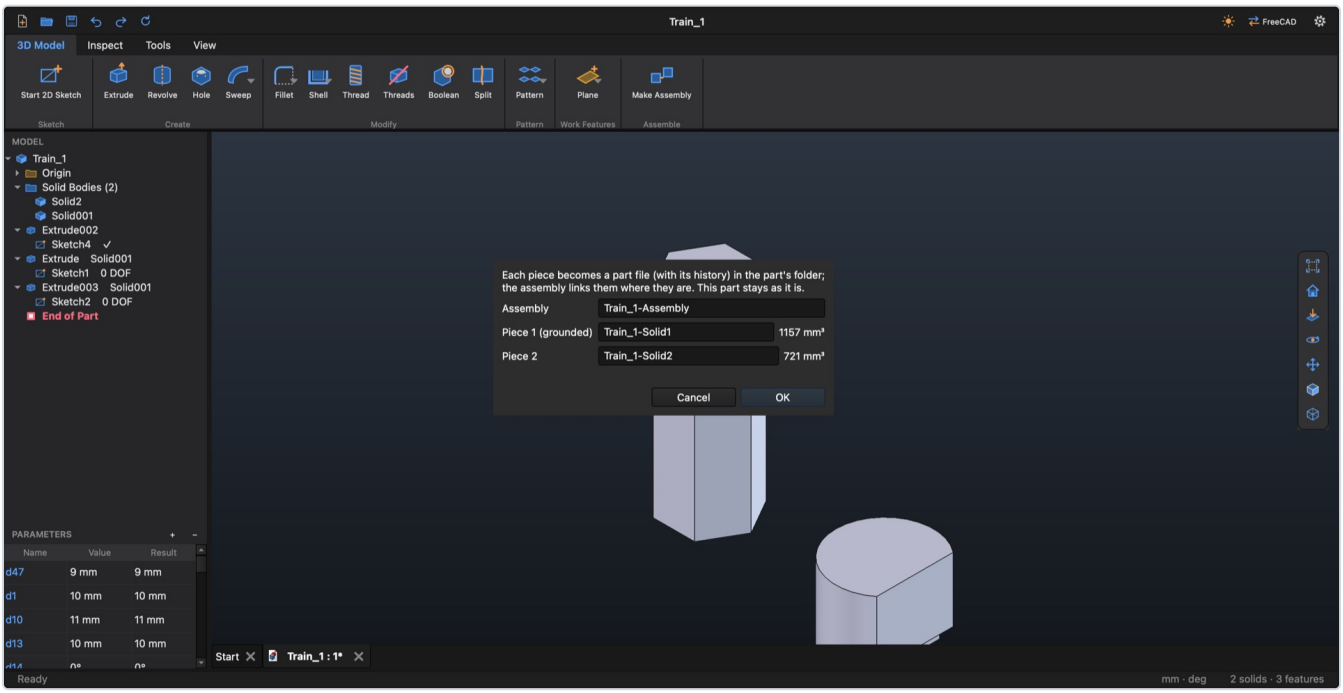


Figure 15. Make Assembly: the names of the new assembly and part files.

- Every separate piece becomes a part file **with its history**; the assembly links them where they were, the largest piece grounded.
- The original part is not changed.
- Running Make Assembly again on the same part offers **Replace existing files** (with the names of the files already there), so the files of the earlier run are overwritten instead of asking for new names. The part itself is never replaced. If one of those files is open with unsaved changes, InCad asks first.
- A part that is one piece cannot be made into an assembly; split it first (Split ▸ Keep all) or make pieces as New Solid.

9.13 Boolean between parts

Assemble ▸ Component ▸ Boolean cuts one part by others, for example a pocket for a bearing:

Field	Meaning
Cut this	The part to cut.
With	The part(s) that cut it.
Clearance	A gap for printed parts (0.2 mm).
Clearance on	**Cavity**, **Tool** or **Split**, as for the part Boolean (6.12).

The pocket is written into the cut part's own file and follows the tools when they move or change. Save that part file too. The cut gets a row under Relationships (Edit, Delete, Rename).

9.14 Threads Off / On in an assembly

Assemble ▸ Component ▸ Threads turns every thread of every part off (faster redraws) and back on. It changes the part files: save them with the assembly.

9.15 Saving

Save saves the file in the active tab. A part edited from the assembly, cut by a Boolean or changed by Threads Off / On is a file of its own: save it as well (switch to its tab, or let **Quit** ask about every changed file).

10 Tips for 3D printing

InCad was made with printed parts in mind. A few habits save reprints.

- **Threads that fit.** Thread and Hole ▸ Tapped have a **Print clearance (on diameter)**, 0.2 mm by default (0.3 mm for a Print-friendly thread). Try it on a small test piece with your printer; raise it if a printed bolt is tight, lower it if it is loose. The **Print-friendly** thread standard has flat crests that print cleanly.
- **Lead-ins.** Use Hole ▸ **Chamfer** (Start or Both ends) and Thread ▸ **Chamfer** so screws and nuts start easily.
- **Parts that fit into each other.** Boolean ▸ Cut with **Clearance (per side)**: on the **Cavity** to print the part with the hole, on the **Tool** to get a slightly smaller "fit" copy of the tool to print, **Split** for half on each.
- **Print the tool as well.** Turn on **Keep tool**: the tool stays a visible solid of its own — the pin and the box with its hole.
- **Too big for the bed?** Draw the cut lines in a sketch, **Split** ▸ **Keep all**, then **Make Assembly**: each piece becomes a part file you can export and print, and the assembly shows them together.
- **Weight and filament.** Tools ▸ Material, then Inspect ▸ Mass Properties for the mass.
- **Fast work.** Turn threads off (Threads) while modeling; turn them on before exporting.

11 Troubleshooting and reporting a problem

When something does not work

1. **Read the status line** and the red text in the dialog: InCad says why a command was refused and what to pick.
2. A dialog is open? Commands like Save and Undo wait for **OK** or **Cancel**.
3. A feature in **red** in the browser: hover over it for the reason, then edit it (double-click).
4. The view or the browser looks out of step with the model: click **Update** on the title strip.
5. Undo (⌘ Z) the last step.
6. Still stuck: save under a new name, quit and restart FreeCAD.
7. **Return to FreeCAD** always gives you FreeCAD's own interface on the same file.

Reporting a problem

Please send:

- what you did, step by step, and what you expected instead;
- the build name (the name of the zip file);
- your macOS version and FreeCAD version (**FreeCAD ▸ About FreeCAD**);
- the log file `~/Library/Logs/InCad.log` — ⚙ ▸ **Show Log File** shows it in the Finder;
- if you can, the .FCStd file you were working on;
- a screenshot if something looks wrong.

If FreeCAD crashed, macOS shows a crash report: please copy its text as well.

Known limits of this build

- macOS on Apple Silicon only; FreeCAD 1.1 (tested with 1.1.3).
- A test build. Save often and work on copies.
- The interface is in English.
- FreeCAD cannot shell a part that already has a modeled thread (InCad offers to shell before the thread).
- Some offsets (clearances) fail on threads and other complex shapes; the dialog says so.
- Move Face moves flat faces along their own direction and straight round walls outward / inward. In Inventor mode it cannot follow a neighbour that is round across the move yet (use Step or Together); Together inward next to fillets or chamfers on a round wall is refused for now.

A Keyboard shortcuts

Single keys work in the mode named. On the Mac, InCad's Ctrl shortcuts are the ⌘ keys.

Key	Command
Part	
S	Start 2D Sketch
E	Extrude
R	Revolve
H	Hole
F	Fillet
Sketch	
L	Line (M: line / arc while drawing)
C	Circle
A	3-Point Arc
R	Rectangle
X	Trim
D	Dimension
Tab	Next value field while drawing
F7	Slice Graphics
F8 / F9	Show / Hide Constraints
Assembly	
P	Place
C	Mate
J	Rigid

Key	Command
Everywhere	
⌘ N	New
⌘ O	Open
⌘ S	Save
⇧ ⌘ S	Save As
⌘ W	Close (asks to save)
⌘ Q	Quit (asks to save)
⌘ Z	Undo
⇧ ⌘ Z	Redo
⌫ / Del	Delete the selection
Esc	Cancel the dialog, stop the tool, finish the sketch
In dialogs and value boxes	
Enter	Apply the value (value box)
↑ / ↓	Dialog value one step up / down
⇧ + ↑ / ↓	Ten steps

B Ribbon map

Every tab, group and command. "A | B | C" is one split button: A is shown, B and C are on its arrow.

Part

Tab	Group	Commands
3D Model	Sketch	Start 2D Sketch
	Create	Extrude · Revolve · Hole · Sweep | Loft | Coil · Emboss
	Modify	Fillet | Chamfer · Shell | Draft · Thread · Threads (Threads Off / On) · Boolean · Split · Move Face
	Pattern	Rectangular | Circular | Mirror
	Work Features	Plane | Axis | Point
	Assemble	Make Assembly
Inspect	Measure	Measure | Distance | Angle | Length | Area · Mass Properties
Tools	Material	Material
	Options	Return to FreeCAD · Ask on New
View	Appearance	Light / Dark
	Navigate	Zoom All · Home View · Look At · Zoom Selection · Orbit · Pan
	Visual Style	Shaded · Wireframe · Section | Section by 3 Points · Hide / Show | Show All Origin | Hide All Origin · Assembly Context
	Windows	Parameters

Sketch

Tab	Group	Commands
Sketch	Create	Line | Single Line · Spline | Control-Vertex Spline · Circle | 3-Point Circle | Ellipse | 3-Point Ellipse · 3-Point Arc | Center Arc | Elliptical Arc · Rectangle | Center Rectangle | 3-Point Rectangle | 3-Point Center Rect. | Rounded Rectangle · Center-to-Center Slot | Overall Slot | Center Point Slot | Arc Slot | Flat-End Arc Slot · Hexagon | Triangle | Square | Pentagon | Octagon | Polygon (N sides) · Point · Text
	Modify	Fillet | Chamfer · Trim · Extend · Offset
	Pattern	Rectangular | Circular | Along Path · Mirror
	Dimension	Dimension | Overall Dimension
	Constrain	Coincident · Concentric · Horizontal · Vertical · Parallel · Perpendicular · Tangent · Equal · Symmetric · Fix · List (Constraint List)
	Insert	Project (Project Geometry)
	Format	Construction · Constraints (Show / Hide Constraints) · Free DOF (Show Free Geometry) · Slice (Slice Graphics)
	Exit	Finish Sketch

View	Appearance	Light / Dark
	Navigate	Zoom All · Home View · Orbit · Pan
	Visual Style	Shaded · Wireframe · Section | Section by 3 Points
	Windows	Parameters

Assembly

Tab	Group	Commands
Assemble	Component	Place · Create · Ground · Boolean · Threads (Threads Off / On)
	Constrain	Mate · Flush · Angle · Parallel · Perpendicular · Tangent · Insert
	Joint	Rigid · Rotational · Slider · Cylindrical · Ball
View	Appearance	Light / Dark
	Navigate	Zoom All · Home View · Look At · Zoom Selection · Orbit · Pan
	Visual Style	Shaded · Wireframe · Section | Section by 3 Points · Hide / Show · Degrees of Freedom
	Windows	Parameters

No file open

Tab	Group	Commands
Get Started	New	New · New Assembly · Open
View	Appearance	Light / Dark

Commands only in the marking menus: Show in Browser, Show in Window, Move End of Part Here, Suppress / Unsuppress, Rename, Delete, Edit, Stop Tool, Edit Pattern, Delete Pattern, Suppress (part), Remove from Assembly.